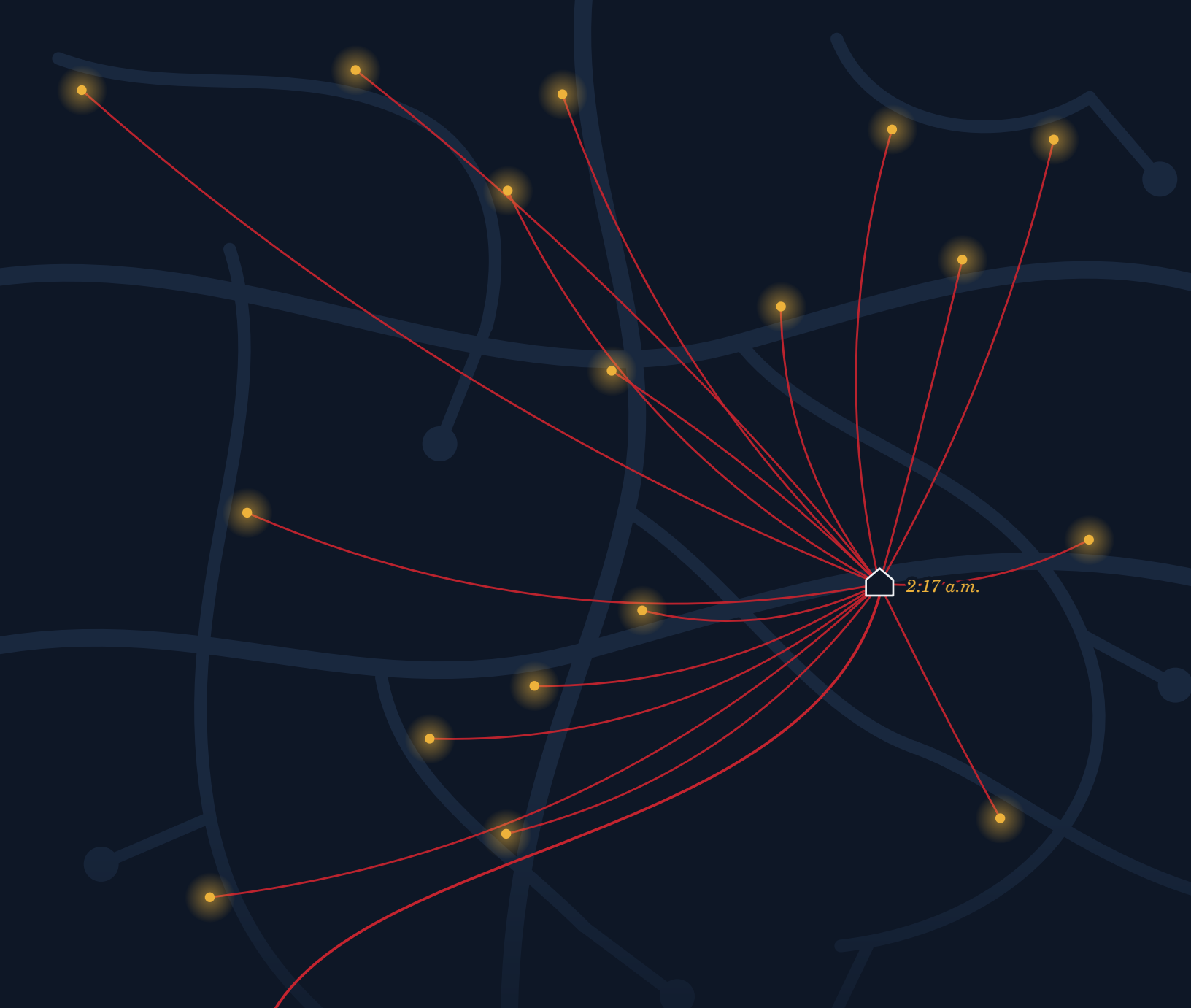


Strings Equally Wound

Sympathetic Violence and the Pharmacology of Mourning in Zach Cregger's Weapons *(2025)*

A dissertation in film philosophy, comparative mythology, and horror studies
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Abstract

This dissertation offers a sustained philosophical, mythographic, and formal reading of Zach Cregger's *Weapons* (2025), a chaptered horror film in which seventeen children from a single elementary-school classroom rise from their beds at 2:17 a.m., run into the dark with their arms flung out like the wings of toy aeroplanes, and vanish, leaving one classmate behind. Against interpretations that resolve the film into a single allegory (of school shootings, of addiction, of grief), it argues that *Weapons* is an inquiry into the conditions under which persons become instruments, and that the film's answer lies in a concept it dramatizes everywhere and names nowhere: sympathy. Synthesizing James George Frazer's law of contagion, the moral theories of sympathy advanced by David Hume and Adam Smith, and the indexical theory of the photographic image descending from Charles Sanders Peirce through André Bazin and Roland Barthes, the study proposes the category of **sympathetic violence**: violence that travels along the very bonds of kinship, proximity, touch, grief, and spectatorship through which communities constitute themselves.

The witch Gladys is read not as an exterior monster but as a virtuosa of sympathy, a technician who converts the residues persons shed into channels of command. The town's misdirected witch-hunt against the schoolteacher Justine Gandy is read as the same circuitry running in the register of affect. The film's own form, with its relay of focal characters, its doorbell-camera footage, and its child narrator, is read as a third circuit binding the spectator to the vanished. Successive chapters situate the film against René Girard's scapegoat mechanism and Jacques Derrida's *pharmakos*/*pharmakeus*; Sigmund Freud on the uncanny, on mourning, and on the primal horde; Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok's crypt; Martin Heidegger's standing-reserve, Simone Weil's analysis of force, and Hannah Arendt's account of violence as instrumental; Barbara Creed's monstrous-feminine and Silvia Federici's political economy of the witch-hunt; Euripides' *Bacchae* and Walter Benjamin's critique of violence. Its comparative corpus runs from the Hamelin legend, *Hansel and Gretel*, Baba Yaga, Lamia, and Lilith to *Rosemary's Baby*, *Suspiria*, *Don't Look Now*, *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, *Prisoners*, *Get Out*, *Hereditary*, *The Witch*, *Coraline*, and Cregger's own *Barbarian* (2022).

Abstract

The dissertation concludes that *Weapons* stages an **aporia of deliverance**: the captive children can be freed only by being weaponized once more, so that liberation must borrow the grammar of possession. The film's closing turn from spell to speech, from sorcery to legend, is read as its tentative proposal that narration is the one *pharmakon* capable of circulating sympathy without converting it into command. The contribution is threefold: a reconstruction of the film's fabula and polyphonic syuzhet; a comparative mythography of the child-taking crone; and a general theory of sympathetic violence portable to horror studies at large.

Prefatory Note

Method, Corpus, Conventions

The primary text is the theatrical cut of *Weapons* (New Line Cinema / Warner Bros. Pictures, released 8 August 2025, 128 minutes), written, directed, produced, and co-scored by Zach Cregger, photographed by Larkin Seiple and edited by Joe Murphy (production record). A secondary corpus comprises the director's published interviews, which constitute an unusually rich paratextual archive: Cregger has named *Magnolia* (1999) and *Prisoners* (2013) as pervasive models, added *Hereditary* (2018), *Picnic at Hanging Rock* (1975), and *The Virgin Suicides* (1999) as examples of what he calls suburban noir, acknowledged debts to *The Shining* (1980), and disclosed that the running children were scripted, on the screenplay's first page, after the photographed girl fleeing a napalm strike (Schiller 2025). Jennifer Egan's chaptered novel *A Visit from the Goon Squad* (2010) is a further acknowledged source. The script was begun in the aftermath of the sudden death of his friend and collaborator Trevor Moore, and its final chapter draws on his father's alcoholism and his own (Galuppo 2025).

The method is symptomatic without being reductive. Authorial testimony is treated as evidence but not as verdict, a position that the Wimsatt–Beardsley critique of the intentional fallacy (1946) and Barthes's death of the author (1967) would require in any case, but which Cregger's own poetics independently licenses. He describes composition as a deliberate abdication of conscious control, a mediumistic conduit for the subconscious, summarized in his formula: "If I intellectualize it, it's dead" (Schiller 2025). A work produced under that discipline invites a reading attentive to latent structure, condensation, and displacement, which is to say a reading that treats the film rather as Freud treated the dream: as a rebus whose figures signify by their arrangement rather than their manifest likeness. The comparative method is mythographic in the tradition of Frazer, Propp, and Lévi-Strauss, attending to recurrent functions and oppositions across folk narrative, classical myth, and modern horror, while remaining alert to the historical specificity that Jack Zipes and Silvia Federici have insisted such universalizing gestures obscure.

Narratological terms follow the Russian Formalist distinction, refined by David Bordwell, between *fabula*, the chronological chain of story events the viewer infers, and *syuzhet*, the order and manner in which the film discloses them. The film's six segments are named for their focal characters and are cited here in quotation marks. Dialogue is paraphrased rather than transcribed. Plot details follow the release version, including its narrated coda, which was added

after test audiences reacted poorly to an original ending on a silent image of the boy Matthew (production record).

The syuzhet: six focal segments

Segment	Focal consciousness	Principal withholding	Principal disclosure
"Justine"	Justine Gandy, third-grade teacher under communal suspicion	The agent of the disappearance	The Lilly house: newspapered windows, motionless parents
"Archer"	Archer Graff, contractor and father of the vanished Matthew	Any supernatural cause	Doorbell footage whose vectors converge; the dream of the rifle over the house
"Paul"	Paul Morgan, married police officer and Justine's former lover	What occurs inside the house	The needle-stick, the dashcam, Paul's entry into the house
"James"	James, an unhoused addict and burglar	The witch's identity and motive	The seventeen children standing in the basement
"Marcus"	Marcus Miller, principal	Gladys's history in the household	Gladys in person; the operation of the hex on Marcus and Terry
"Alex"	Alex Lilly, the child who remained	Nothing essential	Gladys's arrival, regime, ritual, and destruction

The fabula reconstructed

1 Alex's mother admits Gladys, an ailing, distant, and unhoused relative, to the family home; a small thorned tree is installed in her room.

2 Gladys, abruptly rejuvenated, places both parents in a trance, compels them to injure themselves as leverage over Alex, and charges the boy with keeping them alive on canned soup.

3 Her recovery falters. She requires personal effects from each of Alex's seventeen classmates; Alex takes their name tags from the classroom cubbies.

4 On a Wednesday night at 2:17 a.m. the ritual is performed. Seventeen children leave their homes running, arms flung outward, converge on the Lilly house, and are kept standing in the basement while Gladys feeds on their vitality.

5 Justine finds only Alex in class. Parents turn on her at a community meeting; she is placed on leave; the word WITCH is painted in red on her car; she relapses into drinking and sleeps with Paul.

6 Justine follows Alex home and finds the windows papered over and the parents immobile; while she sleeps in her car, Alex's entranced mother cuts a lock of her hair.

7 Archer collates doorbell footage and maps the children's trajectories; he and Justine are visited in dreams by the same garishly painted old woman.

8 Paul, pricked by a needle while searching James, strikes him on camera and releases him. James burgles the Lilly house, sees the children, and runs for the reward; Paul pursues him, takes him to the house, enters alone, and later drags him inside. Both become instruments.

9 Gladys presents herself to Marcus at school. When he insists on a welfare visit, she takes a lock of his husband Terry's hair, hexes Marcus into killing Terry, and dispatches him after Justine.

10 Marcus attacks Justine at a gas station; Archer intervenes; Marcus, pursuing her car, is killed in traffic. Archer and Justine reconcile and identify the Lilly house as the point of convergence.

11 At the house Justine crosses a protective salt line; the bewitched Paul and James attack, and Justine shoots both dead. Gladys bewitches Archer in the basement and turns him on Justine.

12 Alex retrieves a hair from inside Gladys's wig, binds it to one of her twigs, and breaks it. The seventeen children burst from the house, pursue Gladys through the neighbourhood, and destroy her.

13 The spell breaks. Archer is freed; the others remain catatonic. Justine finds Alex holding his parents; Archer carries Matthew home.

14 Coda: the parents are institutionalized and Alex goes to live with another aunt. The children return home, and some, in time, begin to speak again.

Introduction

The Empty Classroom

The founding image of *Weapons* is an absence with an author: seventeen empty desks that are not merely vacant but evacuated. A classroom emptied by fire, illness, or holiday is a site of loss; a classroom emptied by the synchronized flight of its occupants at 2:17 a.m. is a site of *agency*, and agency without a visible agent is the precise condition that Mark Fisher, in *The Weird and the Eerie* (2016), identified as the eerie: the sense that something has acted where nothing should, or that nothing remains where something should. The question the film poses is therefore not only *who* took the children but *how persons can be moved*: by what medium a will can travel from one body into another and make it run.

Three allegories and their common root

The film's critical reception has resolved this question into three rival allegories. The first reads the vanished classroom as a displaced image of the American school shooting, a reading encouraged by Archer Graff's dream of an assault rifle hanging over a suburban roof with the fatal hour inscribed in its body, and resisted by Cregger, who has said he cannot account for the image and was writing from a personal rather than a national place (Schiller 2025). The second reads the film as a work of mourning, composed in the wake of Trevor Moore's death. The third, authorized by Cregger's statement that the final chapter is autobiographical, reads Gladys as the alcoholism that occupied his childhood home; he has described her as a foreign substance whose arrival alters everyone's behaviour (Gizmodo 2025).

This dissertation contends that the three are not competitors but three appearances of one structure. Each describes a bond that ought to protect and instead transmits harm: the bond of the school to the child it shelters, the bond of the survivor to the lost, the bond of the child to the parent. Each also describes a *medium*, something that travels along the bond: a projectile, a grief, a drug. The film's horror lies in the discovery that these media share a single grammar. That grammar is sympathy.

Thesis: sympathetic violence

The word *sympathy* has three histories, and the film activates all of them. In anthropology, James George Frazer's *The Golden Bough* (1890; abridged 1922) named "sympathetic magic" the belief that things act upon one another at a distance through a secret bond, whether because they resemble each other (the law of similarity) or because they were once in contact (the law of contagion). In moral philosophy, David Hume's *Treatise of Human Nature* (1739–40) and Adam Smith's *Theory of Moral Sentiments* (1759) made sympathy the medium through which passions pass between persons and through which moral community becomes possible. In the theory of the photographic image, a line running from

Charles Sanders Peirce's index through André Bazin and Roland Barthes describes the photograph as a trace physically caused by its referent, a sign bound to its object by contact rather than likeness. *Weapons* places these three sympathies in a single town and shows them to be one force.

The category this study proposes is **sympathetic violence**: violence that does not cross the gap between bodies by impact, as a blow or a bullet does, but rides a tie that already exists, whether kinship, proximity, touch, love, grief, or spectatorship. Because such violence travels along bonds, it is available to whoever controls their material residue: a lock of hair, a name tag, a photograph, a reputation. The film stages the difference between the two violences with diagrammatic clarity. Justine's gunshots in the Lilly house kill two men who are only instruments and leave the agent untouched; only a counter-hex, routed through a hair taken from inside the witch's own wig, can reach Gladys. Kinetic violence strikes weapons. Sympathetic violence reaches wielders.

Strings equally wound

The title of this study is taken from Hume, who compared the communication of passions between persons to strings equally wound up, in which the motion of one passes to the rest (*Treatise* 3.3.1). The phrase is apt in a way Hume could not have intended. Gladys's spell is performed by winding a victim's hair or token around a thorned twig, and the participle carries its homograph: to be *wound* about a thorn is to be *wounded*. A second string lies behind the first. In *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) Freud described his grandson throwing a wooden reel, tethered by a string, out of sight and drawing it back, uttering the syllables Freud heard as *fort* (gone) and *da* (there): the child's first mastery of a mother's absence. *Weapons* is a vast *fort*/*da* staged by a grieving author: children who are gone, then there; tethered by a string of hair that can be pulled from a basement in the dark.

The pharmacology of mourning

The subtitle names the second axis. Cregger has described the film as two experiences of pain and grief, a death and an addiction, placed in dialogue (Bloody Disgusting 2025). Jacques Derrida's reading of Plato's *Phaedrus* in "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) showed that the Greek *pharmakon* means at once remedy and poison, and that its semantic field includes the *pharmakeus*, the sorcerer or poisoner, and the *pharmakos*, the scapegoat expelled from the city in time of crisis. Nearly every adult in Maybrook is medicating something. Justine drinks; Paul, who has been sober, relapses beside her; James lives by the needle; the Lilly parents are narcotized into furniture; and Gladys, who arrives claiming illness, has found that the only drug strong enough for her is other people. Mourning and

addiction share a structure: each is a fixation on an object that has become toxic, and each handles traces, the photograph or the bottle, as if the trace could restore what it signifies. The town's search for a witch is itself a pharmacology, an anaesthetic administered to a community that cannot bear an event without a cause.

Plan of the work

Chapter I analyses the film's polyphonic architecture and its debts to *Rashomon*, *Magnolia*, *Pulp Fiction*, Egan, and Cregger's own *Barbarian*, arguing that the chaptered form distributes the stages of grief synchronically across bodies. Chapter II reads the town as an eerie commons of unequal grievability, with Fisher, Freud, Judith Butler, and the cinema of unexplained disappearance. Chapter III treats the witch-hunt against Justine through Girard, Derrida, Evans-Pritchard, Mary Douglas, Federici, and the Salem tradition of spectral evidence. Chapter IV reconstructs Gladys's sorcery as a technology of the trace, mapping Frazer's two laws onto Peirce and Jakobson and assembling a comparative mythography of the child-taking crone. Chapter V reads the weaponized body through Heidegger's standing-reserve, Simone Weil's analysis of force, Arendt's account of violence as instrumental, Kant's formula of humanity, and the Haitian *zombi* refracted through Wade Davis. Chapter VI turns to the crone in the crypt, the captured household, and the politics of the monstrous-feminine and the ageing body. Chapter VII reads the climactic dismemberment as *sparagmos* through Euripides, Freud, Girard, Benjamin, and Bakhtin. Chapter VIII assembles these materials into a general theory of sympathetic violence and argues that cinema itself, as an indexical and bodily medium, is the film's final and most implicating instance. The Conclusion considers what the film offers in place of the spell: speech, slowly recovered, and a legend told by a child.

I

Polyphonic Architecture

Chaptering, Focalization, and the Folkloric Frame

The chaptered form of *Weapons* is not a delivery mechanism for a mystery but a formal model of the community the mystery wounds: a single grief dispersed across several bodies, each permitted to know only what its position allows, and each rehabilitated by the chapter that follows it.

I.1 Ancestry of the chaptered film

The obvious ancestor is Akira Kurosawa's *Rashomon* (1950), adapted from Ryūnosuke Akutagawa's "In a Grove" (1922), whose incompatible testimonies about a single crime gave the language its name for perspectival irreconcilability. *Weapons* is not Rashomonic in that sense. Its perspectives do not contradict one another; they are partial, and their partiality is a function of position rather than of mendacity. Each segment re-enters the same month of aftermath from a new vantage, so that the film proceeds by accretion rather than refutation: a *cumulative* rather than a *contradictory* polyperspectivalism.

Cregger's own genealogy points elsewhere. Paul Thomas Anderson's *Magnolia* (1999), which he has said is all over the film (Schiller 2025), supplies four structural elements. It opens with a prologue narrator recounting improbable local events as if they were true; it assembles a mosaic of damaged adults including addicts, dying fathers, and a lonely police officer; it lets their storylines graze one another in the same few days; and it resolves them not by detection but by an irruption of the absurd and the plagal, the biblical rain of frogs that Anderson took from Exodus. The officer Jim Kurring loses his gun and has it returned to him out of the sky. *Weapons* inherits the ensemble of the medicated and the compromised, and its climax, in which seventeen children burst through doors and windows in pursuit of a single old woman, is its own plague of frogs: an event so excessive that it converts tragedy into something perilously close to slapstick, and thereby completes it.

Quentin Tarantino's *Pulp Fiction* (1994) is the nearer model for titled, nonlinear chapters, but Tarantino's episodes are discontinuous anecdotes connected by contingency; Cregger's are overlapping replays of the same days. Jennifer Egan's *A Visit from the Goon Squad* (2010), another acknowledged source, is closer still. Egan gives each chapter to a different consciousness, folds time back and forth across decades, and entrusts one chapter to a twelve-year-old girl's slide-show journal. Her novel's governing figure is time as an assailant, the goon of the title. That figure returns in Archer's dream, where the hour 2:17 is fused into the body of a rifle: time literalized as a weapon. Gladys, whose entire project is a war against her own senescence, is Egan's goon made flesh.

The last ancestor is Cregger's own *Barbarian* (2022), whose mid-film rupture abandons its heroine to follow a different protagonist and thereby reorganizes, retroactively, what the audience thought it had been watching. *Weapons* generalizes that rupture into a system. Every chapter break is a small *Barbarian*.

I.2 Withholding as ethics

In Gérard Genette's terms, the film practises variable internal focalization; in Meir Sternberg's, it administers gaps that generate curiosity about the past, suspense about the future, and surprise at their juncture. Roland Barthes's account in *S/Z* (1970) of the hermeneutic code, with its enigmas, delays, snares, and partial answers, describes the mechanism exactly. Manohla Dargis objected that the segmentation and overlap amount to a series of delaying tactics (production record). The objection is accurate and beside the point, because delay is the film's content. For five chapters the viewer inhabits the epistemic condition of Maybrook, a town that knows the effect and not the cause, and is released from it only by the testimony of the one child who remained.

The withholding also has an ethical shape that the objection misses. Each chapter rehabilitates a figure the previous one rendered suspect or contemptible. Justine, seen first as the object of a community's suspicion, becomes through her own chapter a frightened and decent woman. Archer, the most venomous voice at the community meeting and almost certainly the author of the red graffiti on her car, becomes through his a father sleeping in his son's bed. Paul, the adulterous and violent officer, is shown in his to be a man on the edge of destroying his own life. James, an addict the town would not mourn, becomes the first adult to see the truth. Marcus, the gentlest man in the film, is turned into a killer, and the film insists that he is not one. The form thus performs the opposite of a scapegoating: it refuses the town its single culprit by giving every suspect a chapter. Chapter III will argue that this is the film's deepest moral argument and that it is made at the level of structure before it is made at the level of plot.

I.3 The synchronic distribution of grief

Asked whether the perspectives represent parts of himself, Cregger assented without hesitation. He identified with Justine's alcoholic outsourcing of her inner life to work and drink, with Archer's rage, which he glossed as the second stage of grief, and with Paul's temptation to burn his life to the ground (Schiller 2025). The reference to stages invokes Elisabeth Kübler-Ross's *On Death and Dying* (1969), whose sequence of denial, anger, bargaining, depression, and acceptance is diachronic, a passage through time. *Weapons* converts the sequence into a simultaneity. Its community is a single mourner whose stages are distributed across bodies rather than across months: denial and depression in Justine, anger in Archer, bargaining and self-destruction in Paul, abjection in James, institutional decency in Marcus, and in Alex the terrible acceptance of a child who has already learned to care for his parents.

This is why Mikhail Bakhtin's concept of polyphony, the coexistence of independent and unmerged consciousnesses that he found in Dostoevsky, fits the film

only with a correction. Its voices are distinct, but they are distinct fractions of one grief. The structure is better described as a *polyphonic monody*: a single voice that can only be heard by being split. Carl Jung's subjective level of dream interpretation, in which every figure in a dream is read as an aspect of the dreamer, offers the appropriate hermeneutic, and Cregger's mediumistic account of composition invites it. The film is organized like a dream of its author, with the condensation, displacement, and pictorial rebus that Freud attributed to the dream-work. Gladys condenses death, addiction, and the elder who cannot be refused; the town displaces its grief onto a teacher; the floating rifle is a rebus to be read sign by sign rather than as a picture.

I.4 The child narrator and the folkloric frame

The film is introduced and closed by an unseen girl (voiced by Scarlett Sher) who tells the story as something that really happened in her town. The device belongs to the folklore of the playground and the campfire, the genre Iona and Peter Opie documented in *The Lore and Language of Schoolchildren* (1959) and that Jan Harold Brunvand anatomized in *The Vanishing Hitchhiker* (1981), where authority rests on the attestation of a friend of a friend. Its cinematic cousins are the counterfeit historical framing of Peter Weir's *Picnic at Hanging Rock* (1975), which Cregger cites, the spurious true-story title card of the Coens' *Fargo* (1996), and above all the retrospective collective narration of *The Virgin Suicides*, also cited, in which neighbourhood boys, grown into middle age, assemble the fragments of a suburban disappearance they never understood. Peter Debruge's comparison of the film to a Grimm bedtime story, the cruel kind rather than the sanitized one, identifies the register (production record).

The frame has a revealing production history. The film originally ended on a silent image of Matthew, and the narrated coda was added after test audiences responded poorly. In *The Interpretation of Dreams* (1900) Freud called the final operation of the dream-work *secondary revision*: the waking mind's attempt to impose intelligibility on material that was not composed to be intelligible. The added voiceover is secondary revision in the most literal sense, a narrative smoothing laid over a dream at the moment of waking.

A folkloric precedent sharpens the point. In the version of the Hamelin legend the Brothers Grimm recorded in their *Deutsche Sagen* (1816–18), two children who fell behind the piper's procession returned: one blind, who could tell but not show where the others went, and one mute, who could show but not tell. The legend thus encodes, at its origin, the problem of testimony maimed by the event it would testify to. *Weapons* reproduces it precisely. Its returned children are mute, and some only slowly regain speech. The story must therefore be told by a child who was not taken, as the remaining Hamelin children and the lame boy of Robert Browning's 1842 poem told theirs.

I.5 Overture

The opening sequence is scored to George Harrison's "Beware of Darkness" (1970), a song of Vedantic caution against the illusions and seducers that cloud perception (production record). The choice is an overture in the operatic sense. Over the image of children running into the night it announces the film's subject, which is not darkness but beguilement: the transfer of a will into a body that does not know it is no longer its own. When Justine later plays Harry Nilsson's "Gotta Get Up", a buoyant song about waking into adult obligation after youthful nights, written by a singer whose drinking became legend, the soundtrack's pharmacological undertone surfaces. Even the film's music is medicated.

II

The Eerie Commons

Absence, Mourning, and the Refused Allegory

For five of its six chapters *Weapons* is a film about a community organized around an absence it cannot attribute, and its most debated image, the rifle in Archer's dream, is best understood not as an allegory the director forgot to deny but as a condensation in Freud's strict sense: a single figure standing at the intersection of several unconscious chains.

II.1 The eerie and the question of agency

Fisher distinguished the weird, a presence that does not belong, from the eerie, which arises from a failure of absence or a failure of presence and which always raises the question of agency: what kind of agent is acting here, and is there one at all? The empty desks, the seventeen unmade beds, and the doorbell recordings of children leaving their houses are textbook eerie objects. The recordings are especially precise. One review observed that the children appear to run toward something rather than away from it (Hollywood Reporter 2025). The vector, not the image, carries the dread, because a vector implies a pole.

The film's arc can be described in Fisher's terms as a passage from the eerie, through the weird, to the grotesque. The eerie governs the first four chapters; the weird arrives with Gladys in Marcus's office, painted and wigged like something that does not belong in a principal's chair; the grotesque governs the climax. William Bibbiani's complaint that the ending squanders the more powerful possibilities the film had invited viewers to entertain (production record) registers, accurately, the dissipation that Fisher held to be the eerie's fate whenever an agent is identified. The question is whether the film has anything to offer in exchange for the eerie it spends. This dissertation argues that it does: the exchange of an unknowable agency for a knowable *mechanism*, which turns out to be more disturbing than the mystery, because it is a mechanism we share.

Freud's essay "The Uncanny" (1919) supplies the domestic coordinates. The *unheimlich* is the *heimlich* turned inside out, the familiar estranged, and Freud took his central example from E. T. A. Hoffmann's "The Sandman" (1816), with its automaton Olimpia and its thief of eyes. Ernst Jentsch, whom Freud was answering, had located the uncanny in uncertainty about whether a figure is animate. The Lilly parents, seated motionless behind windows papered with newsprint, are Olimpia's suburban descendants: bodies that are alive and not inhabited. The house itself has been blinded, its windows sealed like the eyes Coppelius threatens to take.

II.2 Mourning, melancholia, and the incorporated child

Freud's "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917) describes mourning as labour, a withdrawal of attachment from the lost object performed piece by piece, each memory and expectation summoned, intensely invested, and released.

Melancholia refuses the labour; it takes the lost object into the self, and the ambivalence once directed at the object is turned upon the ego. Archer's behaviour is a clinical portrait of the second condition. He sleeps in Matthew's bed, occupying the place of the absent child as if to incorporate him, and the hostility a melancholic turns inward he turns outward upon Justine, the nearest available surrogate for an unknowable cause.

Cregger has said that writing the film was a way of indulging the sensation of missing someone and of never being permitted to ask what happened or why (Bloody Disgusting 2025). The fantasy is clear: the lost could come back. The film grants it and withholds it at once. The children return, but mute and catatonic, and only some recover speech. Jacques Derrida's meditations on mourning, gathered in *The Work of Mourning* (2001) and theorized in *Specters of Marx* (1993), insist on exactly this aporia: successful mourning betrays the dead by assimilating them, while failed mourning keeps them alive as an unassimilable other. Maybrook's returned children are neither assimilated nor lost. They are back, and not back, and the town will have to learn to live with revenants who share its dinner table.

II.3 Grievability and the economy of loss

Judith Butler argued in *Precarious Life* (2004) and *Frames of War* (2009) that lives are differentially grievable and that the frames through which loss is perceived decide which deaths register as losses at all. *Weapons* is acutely sensitive to this distribution and, at its close, partly complicit in it. The seventeen children are maximally grievable: an entire town mobilizes around them, holds meetings, distributes blame, paints accusations. Terry Miller, murdered in his own home by his bewitched husband, is a death the plot uses and the coda forgets. James, unhoused and addicted, is a life the town would never have mourned; he is shot dead in the Lilly house, and the narrator does not mention him. Paul, Marcus, and the institutionalized Lilly parents fare little better.

One may defend the coda's silence as fidelity to its narrator, a child who reports what children noticed. The defence is sound, and it concedes the point. A child's account of a catastrophe reproduces the community's frame, and the frame of Maybrook, like Butler's frames of war, sorts the bodies it counts from the bodies it spends. The film exposes the hierarchy in its chapters, where James becomes the first adult to see the truth, and then allows its legend to reinstate the hierarchy at the end. The tension is not a flaw to be excused but a datum to be read: legends are how communities forget their expendables.

II.4 The refused allegory

Asleep in his son's bed, Archer dreams that he follows Matthew's trail through the streets and looks up to see an assault rifle suspended above a house, the hour 2:17 displayed in its body like the face of a digital clock. Brian Tallerico wrote that the film's premise is not difficult to read as a school-shooting allegory (production record). Viewers noted that the House of Representatives passed the 2022 assault-weapons ban by 217 votes. Cregger has said that the image simply arrived when he asked himself what would be the most frightening thing to place above a house (Schiller 2025), and he has attributed the numeral to unconscious recall of Room 217 in Stephen King's *The Shining* (Screen Rant 2025).

The attribution is more illuminating than it appears. In King's novel of 1977 (Kubrick changed the number to 237), Room 217 is where the corpse of an old woman rises from a bathtub and tries to strangle a child. The numeral that Cregger's subconscious supplied therefore encodes, before any political reading, the film's own primal scene: a decaying elderly woman laying hands on a boy. The number is overdetermined in Freud's precise sense, a node at which at least two associative chains cross, one leading to a crone and one to a gun. The film's refusal to adjudicate between them is not evasion; it is how condensation looks from outside.

Fredric Jameson's *The Political Unconscious* (1981) offers the frame in which a refused allegory remains an allegory. Social contradictions that cannot be represented directly return as form. The premise of *Weapons* contains every element of the American school catastrophe: an hour, a classroom, a town meeting, a teacher blamed, children who do not come home. The swerve into fairy tale is the symptom, not the cure, of that content. What cannot be shown as itself is shown as witchcraft.

One further source closes the circuit. Cregger has disclosed that the screenplay's first page describes the running children as moving like the girl in the napalm photograph (Schiller 2025), that is, Nick Ut's image of Phan Thị Kim Phúc fleeing a napalm strike at Trảng Bàng in June 1972, arms held out from her burned body. The film's most reproduced image is thus modelled on the most famous photograph of children harmed by an American weapon, with one inversion. Ut's children run away from the weapon; Cregger's run toward it. The source of harm has moved from the exterior of war to the interior of a suburban house. Martha Rosler's photomontage series *House Beautiful: Bringing the War Home* (c. 1967–72), which pasted images of Vietnam into the glossy interiors of American domestic magazines, performed the same operation half a century earlier. *Weapons* brings the war home, and the home turns out to have been armed all along.

II.5 Suburban noir and data without hermeneutics

Cregger has said that horror is most effective when it occupies places so banal that their betrayal feels personal, an elementary school rather than a space station (Schiller 2025). The insight belongs to a lineage running from Robin Wood's account of the American family as the privileged site of the return of the repressed, through David Lynch's severed ear in the lawns of *Blue Velvet* (1986), to the suburban gothic catalogued by Bernice Murphy (2009). *Weapons* adds a specifically twenty-first-century element: the networked doorbell camera. Every child's departure was recorded. The suburb is a distributed panopticon in the sense Michel Foucault derived from Bentham, and it sees everything and understands nothing. Its archive yields only vectors. Meaning appears only when one bereaved man collates the vectors on a map and finds that they point at a single house. The film's quiet critique of surveillance is that data do not interpret themselves. Interpretation, as Chapter IV will argue, requires a reader who thinks the way the witch does.

III

Witch-Hunt

Scapegoat, Pharmakos*, and the Pharmacological Town*

Weapons contains two witches, a false one whom the town persecutes and a true one whom it invites indoors, and the relation between them reproduces, with unusual precision, the chain that Derrida traced from the *pharmakeus* who poisons to the *pharmakos* who is expelled.

III.1

The word on the car

The accusation against Justine takes the form of an inscription: WITCH, daubed in red across the side of her car, most likely by Archer, whose chapter shows him with paint to hand (TV Tropes). The car is a prosthetic body, and the inscription belongs to the tradition of Hester Prynne's scarlet letter, the communal sentence written onto a woman's person; Nathaniel Hawthorne, whose ancestor John Hathorne sat as a magistrate at Salem, understood that the mark is the punishment. One cinematographic detail completes the figure: a low angle on Justine as she tries to speak with Alex places the painted word behind her head like a caption (Culture Crypt).

A chromatic rhyme then does silent interpretive work. Gladys's wig is close in colour to the paint on Justine's car (TV Tropes). The sign is in the right colour and on the wrong woman. The town's accusation anticipates its true referent, as if communal paranoia were half-clairvoyant, and misattributes it, as if clairvoyance could only ever be half. Charles Pulliam-Moore praised the film for showing how communities conjure convenient bogeymen instead of confronting what actually endangers their children (production record). The red is the visible trace of that substitution.

III.2

The single-victim mechanism

René Girard's theory, developed in *Violence and the Sacred* (1972) and *The Scapegoat* (1982), holds that communities in crisis, when ordinary distinctions collapse and mimetic rivalry spreads, discharge accumulated violence upon a single victim, whose expulsion restores peace and is then remembered, falsely, as the removal of a genuine cause. Girard catalogued the stereotypes of persecution: a crisis of undifferentiation; an accusation of crimes that attack the foundations of order, crimes against children prominent among them; victimary signs of marginality; and the violence itself. Maybrook meets every criterion. A school is closed, seventeen families are indistinguishable in bereavement, and the community meeting where Archer denounces Justine is the moment at which undifferentiated grief acquires a single object. The charge is a crime against children. The victimary signs are legible: Justine is unmarried, childless, a drinker, a woman sleeping with a married police officer, and a woman whose profession places her in charge of other people's children.

The film's departure from Girard is instructive. For Girard, the scapegoat is innocent and myth is the narrative that conceals the innocence. *Weapons* exposes Justine's innocence and then supplies a culprit who is not innocent at all. It thus contains both of Girard's genres: a persecution text that reveals the mechanism, followed by a myth in which the mechanism is permitted to succeed because the victim really is guilty. A Girardian critic would observe that the film's exhilarating climax gratifies precisely the appetite for unanimous violence that its first half diagnosed. Chapter VII takes up the objection directly. Here it suffices to note that the structure is a double scapegoating, false and then true, and that the film's moral and its pleasures pull in different directions across the hinge between them.

III.3 *Pharmakon, pharmakeus, pharmakos*

In "Plato's Pharmacy" Derrida showed that the *pharmakon* of the *Phaedrus* means both remedy and poison, and that the word's semantic system includes the *pharmakeus*, sorcerer and poisoner, and the *pharmakos*, the human scapegoat whom Athens drove out during the Thargelia festival, struck, according to ancient testimony, with fig branches and squill. Plato does not use the last word, Derrida conceded, but the system uses it for him. *Weapons* stages the system as plot. The town first casts Justine as *pharmakeus* and treats her as *pharmakos*, expelling her from the school and from civic standing. The true *pharmakeus*, Gladys, becomes in the final movement the true *pharmakos*: driven from the house, pursued through the streets, and destroyed by a crowd. Even the instrument rhymes. The Athenian scapegoat was beaten with branches; Gladys works her sorcery with thorned twigs, and her destruction is set in motion by a broken one.

Cregger's own vocabulary supplies the pharmacology. Describing the autobiographical sources of the Lilly chapter, he characterized Gladys as "this foreign substance" that enters a household and changes everyone's behaviour (Gizmodo 2025). He has also said that he is an alcoholic, sober for a decade, whose father died of cirrhosis (Galuppo 2025). Once one sees Gladys as a substance, the whole town reorganizes itself as a pharmacy. The liquor store is its agora: Justine buys there, James begs outside it, and an enraged mother attacks Justine in it. Paul, sober until Justine draws him into a bar, relapses. James lives by the needle. The Lilly parents are narcotized into furniture. Gladys herself claims to be sick and has discovered that the only effective medicine is the life of children.

The film's most exact pharmacological rhyme is a puncture. When Paul searches James he pricks his finger on a needle in the addict's pocket, and his response is immediate violence, the panic of contagion converted into a blow; the patrol car's camera records it, and the recording drives the rest of his chapter (production record). The scene is the naturalistic double of Gladys's rite, in

which a thorn draws her blood before a victim's token is wound around it. Needle and thorn are the film's two instruments of puncture, one medical and one magical, and both bind bodies through blood. The anxiety the needle provokes in Paul is the anxiety of a bond he did not choose. It is also, in miniature, the thesis of this dissertation.

III.4 The anthropology of accusation

E. E. Evans-Pritchard's *Witchcraft, Oracles and Magic Among the Azande* (1937) argued that witchcraft beliefs do not replace empirical causation but supplement it. Termites explain why a granary collapses; witchcraft explains why it collapsed at the moment particular people were sitting beneath it. Maybrook's question is an Azande question. The town does not lack an account of how children can leave a house at night; it lacks an account of why *these* children, *this* night, *this* class. Into that gap of particular causation the accusation flows.

Evans-Pritchard also distinguished witchcraft, an inherited substance in the body that acts without conscious intent, from sorcery, a learned technique employing medicines and rites. Cregger has said that he offered Amy Madigan two origins for Gladys: a mortal woman using magic to stave off a fatal illness, or a non-human entity imitating human behaviour, and that he never asked which she chose (Deadline 2025). The two options are Evans-Pritchard's sorcerer and witch. The film refuses to decide between technique and essence, between a woman who does evil and a being that is evil, and the refusal is philosophically consequential, because it leaves open whether sympathetic violence is a practice anyone could learn or a nature only some possess.

Mary Douglas, in *Purity and Danger* (1966) and in her edited volume *Witchcraft Confessions and Accusations* (1970), located the witch in the interstices of social structure: accusations proliferate where roles are ambiguous and where dangerous power is attributed to those occupying unstructured positions. A teacher stands *in loco parentis*, neither parent nor stranger. An elderly relative who arrives ill and homeless is neither guest nor household member. The town's error, in Douglas's terms, is not that it sought an interstitial woman but that it chose the wrong interstice.

Silvia Federici's *Caliban and the Witch* (2004) supplies the political economy. The European witch-hunts, she argued, fell disproportionately on older, poorer, and unmarried women, healers and midwives, women outside reproductive discipline, and formed part of the violent disciplining of the female body during the transition to capitalism. Justine and Gladys occupy the two poles of Federici's target population, the unmarried woman of working age and the old, poor, dependent woman. The film's irony is that the town attacks the first while the second shelters inside the most respectable institution available, the family

home, admitted there by the duty of kin to care for a failing elder. Her vector is not transgression but obligation.

III.5 Spectral evidence

At Salem in 1692 the court admitted spectral evidence: testimony that an accused person's shape had appeared to the afflicted in dream or vision. Increase Mather's *Cases of Conscience* (1693) helped end the practice with the maxim that it would be better for ten suspected witches to escape than for one innocent person to be condemned. Arthur Miller's *The Crucible* (1953) made the episode the American allegory of persecution. *Weapons* inverts it. Gladys appears in the dreams of Justine, Archer, and James, and these appearances are veridical; the film's spectral evidence is true. But no one consults it. The community convicts by resemblance and ignores the dreams that show the actual face. Its error is not credulity but the wrong credulity: it believes the metaphor, the woman who looks like a witch, and disregards the index, the visitation that comes from the witch herself. The next chapter shows that this is a precise semiotic error with a precise anthropological pedigree.

III.6 The chapter withheld

Girard argued that the Gospels broke the mythic cycle by narrating persecution from the side of the victim. In that technical sense the chaptering of *Weapons* is evangelical: it narrates, one chapter at a time, from the side of each person the town or the viewer was invited to condemn. One figure is excluded. Gladys never receives a focal chapter. The film grants interiority to everyone it asks us to pardon and withholds it from the one it permits us to destroy. That withholding is a condition of the climax's pleasure, and it is about to be revoked. New Line has scheduled a prequel titled *Gladys* for September 2028, written by Zach Shields from a story developed with Cregger (production record). Girard's logic predicts its content: a franchise that profited from a scapegoat's destruction will next profit from her rehabilitation, granting her the chapter the original refused.

IV

The Law of Contagion

Sympathetic Magic and the Technology of the Trace

Gladys's sorcery is a technology of the trace: it works exclusively through material residues that persons shed into the world, and it therefore obeys what Frazer called the law of contagion, a law that binds the sorcerer as surely as her victims and that ultimately destroys her.

IV.1 The rite

Cregger worked out the mechanics with his production designer, Tom Hammock, and has described the finished procedure. Gladys fills a bowl with water; winds a personal effect of the victim around a thorned branch from the small tree she keeps in her room; coats the branch in her own blood; where paralysis is required, rings a bell engraved with the numeral six and a small inverted triangle; snaps the twig to set the spell in motion; and drops it into the water to end it (Dexerto, summarizing Entertainment Weekly, 2025). His acknowledged sources were Wade Davis's ethnobotanical study of Haitian zombification, *The Serpent and the Rainbow* (1985), and a ritual described in a song by the Mekons. The tree is a blackthorn (Wikipedia, "Aunt Gladys"), long associated in British and Irish folklore with witches, curses, and ill omen. The inverted triangle is the alchemical sign for water, the element in which the spell is extinguished.

The film distinguishes two operations. A token belonging to the *instrument* converts a person into a weapon; the seventeen name tags Alex takes from his classmates' cubbies summon and immobilize the children. A token belonging to the *target* aims the weapon; the strand of Terry's hair turns Marcus upon his husband, and the lock cut from the sleeping Justine by Alex's entranced mother marks her as the next destination (Den of Geek 2025). The grammar is exact: one residue makes the gun, another loads the address.

IV.2 Frazer's two laws

Frazer reduced the principles of magic to two: "that like produces like," and "that things which have once been in contact with each other continue to act on each other at a distance after the physical contact has been severed" (*The Golden Bough*, 1922, ch. 3). He named the first the law of similarity, whose practices he called homoeopathic or imitative magic, and the second the law of contagion; both he called sympathetic, because both assume that things act on one another at a distance through a secret bond. Gladys's magic is almost purely contagious. She makes no effigies, no poppets, no images. She works by hair, ribbon, and name tag: by things that were once in contact with the persons they now command.

The name tag is the film's most philosophically loaded token, because it fuses two kinds of residue. It is contagious, having lived in the child's cubby and on the child's body, and it is nominal, bearing the child's name. Frazer devoted a chap-

ter to the widespread belief that a name is a part of the person, and to the precautions taken to conceal it. The children of Maybrook are summoned by their names written down; they are, in the most literal sense, called.

The script's revision history sharpens the point. In an earlier draft Gladys cast the spell using Valentine's Day cards the classmates had given Alex, and Alex played no part in procuring them; a suggestion from Bill Hader led Cregger to make Alex steal the name tags himself (Hollywood Reporter 2025). Marcel Mauss's *The Gift* (1925) argued that a gift retains something of its giver, the Māori *hau*, which binds receiver to donor and demands return. The first draft weaponized the gift: love tokens, freely given, became channels of capture. The final draft replaces the gift with the theft and the passive recipient with a coerced accomplice. The change moves the film from an economy of reciprocity to an economy of expropriation, and it makes the child complicit in the very mechanism he will later turn against its author. Mauss and Henri Hubert's earlier *General Theory of Magic* (1902–03) had insisted that magic is a social technique whose efficacy depends on collective belief. Gladys's magic, by contrast, requires no believer but herself. It is technique without society, which is one definition of a weapon.

IV.3 Metaphor, metonymy, and the town's semiotic error

In "Two Aspects of Language and Two Types of Aphasic Disturbances" (1956) Roman Jakobson aligned the two poles of linguistic operation, the metaphoric, governed by similarity, and the metonymic, governed by contiguity, with Frazer's homoeopathic and contagious magic and with the operations of Freud's dreamwork. Peirce's distinction between the icon, which signifies by resemblance, and the index, which signifies by a real physical connection, belongs to the same family. The convergence yields a precise diagnosis of Maybrook.

Gladys is a metonymic sorceress. She operates by contiguity: the part for the whole, the hair for the head, the desk for the child, the niece's household for the town. The community searches for the witch metaphorically: it asks who *resembles* a witch, and finds a single drinking woman whose children are not her own. Its hermeneutic is iconic; the evil is indexical. This is the epistemological thesis the film advances beneath its plot: harm travels by contiguity, while communities look for it by resemblance. Spectral evidence fails to register for the same reason. The dreams in which Gladys appears are indices, emanations of the witch herself, and the town has no use for them because it is busy matching faces to a type.

Archer alone escapes the error, and he escapes it by reading the way the witch writes. He ignores what Justine looks like and attends to the vectors in the doorbell footage, plotting them on a map until their contiguity yields a point. Carlo Ginzburg's essay "Clues: Roots of an Evidential Paradigm" (1979) traced a

conjectural mode of knowledge, running from the hunter reading tracks through the art connoisseur Giovanni Morelli, Sherlock Holmes, and Freud, that reasons from marginal and involuntary traces, and he noted its kinship with divination. Archer is a hunter-reader in Ginzburg's lineage. His success suggests the film's most unsettling symmetry: the detective and the sorcerer share an epistemology of the trace, and the only way to find the witch is to think as she does.

IV.4 A comparative mythography of the child-taking crone

The figure of Gladys gathers at least seven older types, which together form a single mythographic field.

The first is the devouring hag of the Grimms' "Hansel and Gretel" (tale type ATU 327A) and of the Slavic Baba Yaga cycle: the old woman who feeds children in order to feed on them. Gladys keeps her captives alive on Alex's soup as the witch of the gingerbread house fattened Hansel, and as in the Grimm tale it is a child's cunning that finally turns her own apparatus against her. Alex is Gretel.

The second is the bereaved devourer. Lamia, in Greek tradition, lost her children by Zeus to Hera's jealousy and became a devourer of other women's children. Her myth is the purest ancient statement of this dissertation's claim that mourning and sorcery are twin economies of the trace: a grief that cannot be worked through becomes a predation upon the living.

The third is the child-stealing demoness warded off by names. In Jewish folklore, transmitted in the medieval *Alphabet of Ben Sira*, Lilith threatens newborns, and amulets inscribed with the names of the angels Senoy, Sansenoy, and Semangelof protect them. In *Weapons* the written name, once apotropaic, becomes the instrument of capture. The family whose house the witch occupies is named Lilly. The resemblance to the demoness's name has no etymological basis; it is a phonic accident of exactly the kind on which folk etymology and dreams both feed, and it places the lair of a Lilith in the house of the Lillys.

The fourth is the Piper of Hamelin, who in 1284, by tradition, led the town's children away with music. Gladys's bell is his pipe. The legend, however, is a moral economy: the town had refused the piper his fee. *Weapons* abolishes the debt. Maybrook owed Gladys nothing, and her taking is not punishment but need, which is more frightening because it implies no covenant whose keeping could have prevented it.

The fifth is the usurping other mother. Neil Gaiman's *Coraline* (2002), adapted by Henry Selick in 2009, gives us the Beldam, who displaces a child's parents, hoards the souls of earlier children, and is defeated when the heroine recovers their traces. Roald Dahl's *The Witches* (1983) adds the iconography: witches who loathe children, hide bald heads beneath wigs, and work by potion. Gladys's wig conceals patchy hair, and the decisive token in the film is a hair Alex finds *inside* the wig. The disguise retains the residue of what it disguises;

the mask carries a trace of the face. No better emblem of Derrida's trace could be devised.

The sixth is the coven that steals belongings. In Roman Polanski's *Rosemary's Baby* (1968) the elderly Castevets and their circle obtain a glove of Rosemary's friend Hutch to strike him into a fatal coma and a necktie of a rival actor to blind him, and Minnie Castevet plies Rosemary with herbal drinks and a pungent charm. The lineage is institutional as well as iconographic. Ruth Gordon won the Academy Award for Best Supporting Actress for Minnie in 1969; Amy Madigan won the same award for Gladys in 2026 (production record). Two garishly dressed elderly witches who steal personal effects, fifty-seven years apart, received the same prize.

The seventh is sympathetic action at a distance as a cinematic set-piece. In Luca Guadagnino's *Suspiria* (2018) a dancer's movements in one studio twist and break the body of another woman in a mirrored room below, the most explicit rendering in recent cinema of a body used as a weapon through a sympathetic bond. In Jordan Peele's *Get Out* (2017), a teaspoon stirred in a cup drops the protagonist into a paralysis in which consciousness watches a body it no longer commands; Gladys's bell performs the same office.

IV.5 The bilaterality of contagion

Contagious magic has no one-way valve. Gladys's rite requires her own blood on the thorn, so every bond she makes passes through her body as well as her victim's. Frazer documented at length the care with which people in many societies disposed of their own cut hair and nail parings, lest an enemy use them. Gladys, the virtuosa of other people's residues, neglects her own. She wears it against her skull, under the wig, in a house where a child she has terrorized is learning her craft by watching. When Alex takes that hair, winds it on her twig, and snaps it, he does not invent a counter-magic. He simply applies her law to its author. The principle by which she binds is the principle by which she is bound, and the next three chapters follow that bilaterality from the body of the instrument, through the household of the crone, to the crowd that tears her apart.

V

Standing-Reserve

The Weaponized Body and the Ontology of the Instrument

The children kept upright and silent in the Lilly basement are the most exact image cinema has yet produced of what Heidegger called standing-reserve: beings ordered to stand by, on call, for a use that is not their own.

V.1

What a weapon is

A weapon is defined by function rather than substance. A kitchen knife, a car, and a word can each become one, and nothing in their matter decides the matter. The film's title, a plural noun without an article, names a category rather than an object, and the narrative distributes the category across nearly every body it shows: seventeen children; Marcus, Paul, James, and finally Archer; the gun Justine fires; the rifle in Archer's dream; the painted word on her car. Aristotle had already supplied the formula for the human instrument. In the first book of the *Politics* he described the slave as a living tool, an *organon empsychon*, a possession that acts. Gladys's sorcery realizes the Aristotelian definition without remainder: her weapons are tools with souls in them, and the souls have been switched off.

Hannah Arendt's *On Violence* (1970) distinguished power, which arises when people act in concert and depends on numbers and assent, from violence, which is distinguished by its instrumental character and always requires implements. By Arendt's criteria Gladys has no power whatever. She persuades no one, assembles no public, commands no assent. She possesses only violence, which is to say instruments, and she must manufacture them one at a time out of the people around her. The climax will pose Arendt's distinction as a riddle. Seventeen children rush in concert upon a single tyrant, an image of collective action if ever there was one, but they do not act; they are acted upon. A crowd of instruments has the appearance of power and the substance of violence.

Kant's formula of humanity in the *Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals* (1785) requires that humanity, in oneself and in others, be treated always at the same time as an end and never merely as a means. Ordinary life is full of permissible use: the employer uses the employee, the patient uses the doctor, and Kant's "merely" marks the line beyond which use becomes violation. The weaponized person lies at the absolute limit of that line, because what is taken is not a service but the capacity to set ends at all. Gladys does not use people within the space of their agency; she abolishes the space. Chapter VII will show that Alex's deliverance of the children cannot satisfy Kant's formula either, and that this failure is the film's darkest structural fact.

V.2

Standing-reserve

In "The Question Concerning Technology" (1954) Heidegger argued that the essence of modern technology is not machinery but a mode of revealing, *Gestell*

or enframing, which challenges everything forth as *Bestand*, standing-reserve: resource ordered to be immediately at hand, stockpiled for further ordering. His examples were the Rhine dammed into a power supply and the forester whose work is ordered by the paper industry; his warning was that human beings, too, would come to be revealed as resource. The Lilly basement is the warning made flesh. The children are kept upright and silent, fed by Alex to remain viable, stored as a reserve of the vitality Gladys draws down. They are standing-reserve in the most literal sense the phrase permits. They *stand*, and they are *reserved*.

The Heideggerian reading also corrects a common misdescription of the film's genre. Gladys's sorcery is not the antithesis of technology but an instance of its essence. Her rite is a procedure: standardized inputs, a sequence of operations, a switch to start and a switch to stop. She regards hair, kinship, and children's names as Heidegger's challenging regards a river: as stock. The suburb she infiltrates is enframed in the same way. Its doorbell cameras order every threshold as a source of data, and the archive they compile is precisely as indifferent to meaning as the witch is to persons. Magic in *Weapons* is not the return of the archaic into modernity. It is modernity's essence appearing without its alibi.

V.3

Force and the thing

Simone Weil's "The Iliad, or the Poem of Force" (1940), written as France fell, defined force as that which turns anyone subjected to it into a thing: a corpse, in its extreme exercise, or in its subtler form a living thing, a suppliant or slave who still breathes but no longer belongs to himself. Weil's second insight was that force petrifies those who wield it as surely as those who suffer it, intoxicating the victor until he too becomes a thing, so that no one in the poem truly possesses force; it passes through them. *Weapons* dramatizes both halves of the analysis. The bewitched are living things in Weil's sense, breathing and inert. And Gladys, intoxicated by the vitality she drinks, grows careless, grandiose, and finally reified: in the last movement she is literally reduced to matter by the instruments she made. The film's moral arc is the arc of the *Iliad* as Weil read it.

The children's posture belongs to the same analysis. The aeroplane arms of their running gait come from the repertoire of play, the gesture of a child pretending to fly, and the film requisitions it for automatism. Chapter II traced the posture to Nick Ut's photograph of a burned girl whose arms are held away from her body by her injuries. Read together, the two sources describe the conversion that force performs: a child's own gesture of freedom, re-staged as the posture a weapon imposes.

V.4 The automaton, the *zombi*, and the dispossessed body

Henri Bergson's *Laughter* (1900) located the comic in something mechanical encrusted upon the living. The formula explains why the possessed of *Weapons* are frightening and funny at once, and why Cregger, a sketch comedian before he was a horror director, is so precise with them. When the bewitched Marcus punches through a car window without registering pain, or sprints after a moving car with a fixed and idiot purpose, the audience is caught on the hinge Bergson described, which Noël Carroll's "Horror and Humor" (1999) later analysed as the shared structure of incongruity that horror supplements with threat. The mechanical encrusted on the living is the definition of the comic and also of the weaponized person.

Cregger's acknowledged source for the possession, Wade Davis's *The Serpent and the Rainbow*, gives the figure its deepest genealogy. Davis argued that Haitian zombification involved a neurotoxic preparation that induced a death-like state, followed by further drugging to keep the victim docile: a pharmacological theory of possession, which unites this chapter with the pharmacology of Chapter III. Davis's findings were disputed, but the figure he studied has an indisputable history. The Haitian *zombi*, as Joan Dayan argued in *Haiti, History, and the Gods* (1995), is a memory of plantation slavery in Saint-Domingue: a body whose will has been captured and put to labour, the instrument without remainder. Hollywood converted it into exotic spectacle with *White Zombie* in 1932. *Weapons* transposes the figure to a white suburb in Pennsylvania and a white elderly witch. The transposition universalizes the *zombi*'s political content, insisting that any body can be expropriated, and in the same gesture erases the historical specificity that gave the figure its force. A responsible reading must hold both effects together.

Get Out provides the decisive comparison. Peele's Armitage family and their guests, elderly and white, purchase young Black bodies and occupy them, consigning the original consciousness to the Sunken Place, from which it can watch but not act. Cregger has cited Peele's film as a model of how an intensely personal story becomes universal (Schiller 2025). The two films describe two modes of parasitic gerontocracy. In Peele's the axis of expropriation is race; in Cregger's it is age and kinship. Both locate the horror in the old taking the bodies of the young, and both insist that the expropriation is conducted through the most intimate social forms available: hospitality in one case, the family in the other.

V.5 The vampire economy

In the tenth chapter of the first volume of *Capital* (1867), Marx wrote that capital is dead labour which, vampire-like, lives only by sucking living labour, and lives the more, the more labour it sucks. The metaphor fits Gladys with uncom-

fortable exactness. She is dying or dead life sustained by the extraction of living vitality; the children are labour-power held in reserve; the Lilly parents are the alienated workers of the household, motionless on the living-room couch, consuming soup they did not cook. Federici argued that the historical witch-hunt served capitalist accumulation. In *Weapons* the witch *is* accumulation.

The family-systems therapists Ivan Boszormenyi-Nagy and Geraldine Spark, in *Invisible Loyalties* (1973), named the condition of the child forced into the role of caregiver to his own parents: parentification. Cregger has described the final chapter in precisely those terms, as an inversion of family roles he lived in a house with an alcoholic parent (Galuppo 2025). Alex feeding his catatonic parents is a parentified child. The economic reading and the clinical reading converge on a single structure. The Lilly parents are held between the demands of an ailing elder and the needs of a young child, the position now commonly called the sandwich generation, and the film imagines the pressure of that position as total paralysis. The horror of *Weapons* is, among other things, the horror of care become extraction.

VI

The Crone in the Crypt

Hospitality, the Monstrous-Feminine, and Parasitic Senescence

Gladys does not break into the Lilly house; she is invited, and the film's most corrosive insight is that the obligations of kinship and care, not their violation, are the vector through which sympathetic violence enters the home.

VI.1 Hospitality, hostility, hostage

Alex's mother admits Gladys as a distant, homeless, and ailing relative (production record). The scene belongs to the oldest moral drama in the Western tradition, the reception of the stranger, governed in Homer by Zeus Xenios and tested in Ovid's tale of Philemon and Baucis. Émile Benveniste's *Indo-European Language and Society* (1969) traced the Latin *hostis*, stranger and enemy, and *hospes*, guest and host, to a common root, and Derrida, in *Of Hospitality* (1997, with Anne Dufourmantelle), compressed the aporia into a coinage, *hostipitality*: the host who opens the door unconditionally exposes the house to the guest who will become its master. The Lilly parents become, in the most literal etymology available, hostages.

The film sets two unhoused figures side by side. James enters the house by burglary and is despised; Gladys enters by kinship and is sheltered. The family's door opens to the elder in need and would close to the addict in need, and it is the welcomed one who destroys it. The structure makes an argument about the boundaries of care: kinship is not the barrier against sympathetic violence but its preferred conduit, because kinship is the bond that cannot be refused.

VI.2 The crypt and the phantom

Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok distinguished two responses to loss in "Mourning or Melancholia: Introjection versus Incorporation" (1972). Introjection assimilates the loss gradually into the self through language. Incorporation is a fantasy of swallowing the lost object whole and preserving it intact, silenced, in a sealed intrapsychic tomb they called the crypt. Abraham's "Notes on the Phantom" (1975) extended the theory across generations: a phantom is an unspeakable family secret that passes from parent to child and haunts descendants who never knew its content.

The Lilly house is a crypt in both senses. Its windows are sealed with newsprint. Its basement holds children preserved intact, silent, neither dead nor alive, behind a wall the town cannot see through. Its occupant is a relative from the edge of the lineage, a family secret who arrives bearing an inheritance no one names. Cregger has called the final chapter the most autobiographical part of the film (Bloody Disgusting 2025), and has spoken of his father's death from cirrhosis and his own alcoholism in the same breath (Galuppo 2025). Addiction transmitted from father to son is a phantom in Abraham's precise sense, and

Gladys, a figure from the family's own blood who takes over the household and must not be spoken of, is its allegorical form.

The clinical literature on alcoholic families supplies a further correspondence. Claudia Black's *It Will Never Happen to Me* (1981) identified three unwritten rules in such households: don't talk, don't trust, don't feel. Gladys's regime enforces all three. She threatens to kill Alex's parents if he tells; she severs him from the teacher who tries to reach him; she renders the adults literally unfeeling. The film's supernatural premise is a precise transcription of a clinical structure.

The basement is Cregger's signature space. In *Barbarian* the house concealed tunnels in which a woman born of incest was kept and in which she attempted, grotesquely, to nurse a captive man. In *Weapons* the basement stores children and the nurse is a child. The lineage runs back to the fruit cellar of *Psycho* (1960), where a son keeps his mother's mummified body and is possessed by her into a weapon, and forward to Jennifer Kent's *The Babadook* (2014), which ends with its heroine keeping her grief alive in the cellar and feeding it, domesticated rather than destroyed. *Weapons* splits the difference: the basement's contents are released, but they emerge mute, still bearing the crypt's silence.

VI.3 The monstrous-feminine and the female grotesque

Barbara Creed's *The Monstrous-Feminine* (1993) catalogued the faces of female monstrosity in horror, among them the archaic mother, the witch, and the possessed body, and grounded them in Julia Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980), where the abject is whatever disturbs identity, system, and order, and the maternal body and the corpse are its privileged figures. Gladys is abjection in the register of age: a patchy scalp beneath a wig, lipstick smeared past the lips, a face painted into a mask, a body that will not consent to die. Entertainment Weekly's description of her as channelling Pennywise (AOL / Entertainment Weekly 2025) names her nearest relative in popular horror: the clown of Stephen King's *It* (1986), who feeds on the children of Derry in cycles, abetted by the adults' forgetting, until the children band together to destroy it.

The clown's paint is philosophically significant. For Emmanuel Levinas the face of the other is an ethical summons, a command, prior to any decision, not to kill. A painted face is a counterfeit face, a surface that solicits address and cannot be addressed. Gladys's makeup is an anti-face. It also links her to Mikhail Bakhtin's grotesque body, whose emblem in *Rabelais and His World* (1965) was a set of terracotta figurines from Kerch depicting laughing, pregnant old women, death and birth in a single body. Gladys is a grotesque inversion of that emblem: an old body swollen not with a life it will give but with lives it has taken. Mary Russo's *The Female Grotesque* (1994) warned that such figures carry both critical energy and the risk of reproducing contempt for the ageing female body.

The risk is real. Federici showed how the old, poor woman became the archetypal witch of the early modern persecutions, and a film whose climax invites an audience to cheer the dismemberment of a painted crone inherits that history whether it intends to or not. Two features of *Weapons* temper the charge. The first is Cregger's account of Gladys as indeterminate: he has wondered aloud whether the true Gladys is the tyrant at the breakfast table or something vulnerable beneath (SlashFilm 2025), and Madigan's performance keeps both in play. The second is the coda, in which Alex goes to live with a different aunt. Bruno Bettelheim's *The Uses of Enchantment* (1976) argued that fairy tales split the mother into a good figure and a wicked one so that the child may hate without destroying the image of love; Jack Zipes contested Bettelheim's universalism in *Breaking the Magic Spell* (1979). Whatever the merits of the theory, *Weapons* performs the split. The aunt-function is not condemned. It is divided, and its benign half receives the child.

VI.4 Parasitic senescence and the war against time

Gladys belongs to a lineage of elders who renew themselves by consuming the young. The legend of Elizabeth Báthory, who was said to bathe in the blood of girls, is historically dubious and culturally indelible. Sheridan Le Fanu's *Carmilla* (1872) feeds an ancient body on young women. Demonological treatises of the fifteenth century, the *Malleus Maleficarum* among them, accused witches of rendering children's bodies into ointments, a belief Robert Eggers made literal in *The Witch* (2015), where an infant is ground into the salve that lets a hag fly and a crone appears to a boy as a young seductress. In Argento's *Suspiria* (1977) and Guadagnino's 2018 version, Mother Markos is an ancient witch whose rotting body requires a young vessel. Ari Aster's *Hereditary*, which Cregger cites, makes the dead grandmother the architect of her family's possession.

The nineteenth-century novel offers the most exact antecedent. In Dickens's *Great Expectations* (1861), Miss Havisham, a decaying old woman in a yellowed bridal dress, stops every clock in her house at the moment of her wound and raises the child Estella as an instrument of revenge against men. She is the English novel's great crone who weaponizes a child, and her stopped clocks anticipate the hour 2:17, at which time in Maybrook ceases to move. Gladys's project is the same war against time, conducted by the same means. Recent cinema has made this war a genre: *The Visit* (2015), *Relic* (2020), Ti West's *X* (2022), and Coralie Fargeat's *The Substance* (2024), to which one reviewer compared *Weapons* (production record). *The Substance* is especially apt, because its instrument of rejuvenation is a drug. The pharmacology of youth and the sorcery of youth turn out to be one subject, and *Weapons* is its fairy-tale form.

VII

Sparagmos

Counter-Sorcery, Collective Violence, and the Aporia of Deliverance

The climax of *Weapons* frees seventeen children by weaponizing them a second time, and the film's refusal to disguise this fact constitutes an aporia of deliverance: in a world organized by sympathetic violence, liberation can only be spoken in the grammar of possession.

VII.1 The *Bacchae* in the suburbs

The master intertext is Euripides' *Bacchae* (405 BCE). Dionysus, god of wine and ecstatic possession, returns to Thebes, the city of his mortal mother, disguised as a foreign stranger. His cousin, King Pentheus, refuses to recognize him. Dionysus maddens the women of the city and draws them to Mount Cithaeron, lures Pentheus there to spy on them, and lets the possessed women, led by Pentheus's own mother Agave, tear the king apart with their bare hands, the rite the Greeks called *sparagmos*. Agave carries her son's head back to Thebes believing it to be a lion's.

The film distributes the play's roles with an inversion that is its signature. Gladys is Dionysus: the kin who arrives as a stranger, the possessor of minds, and, in Cregger's own allegory, the foreign substance whose god Dionysus literally is. But Gladys is also Pentheus, the one torn apart. *Weapons* fuses the possessor and the sacrificial victim in a single body, so that the god of the intoxicating substance is dismembered by her own maenads. The seventeen children are maenads in every functional respect: possessed, endowed with impossible strength, indifferent to walls, windows, and doors (Den of Geek 2025), and they break the witch's head as Agave carried her son's. The film's preoccupation with heads, which also includes Marcus's crushed in traffic, is the preoccupation of a drama about sovereignty. The head is the seat of command; to destroy it is to abolish the commander, not merely to kill the body.

Read through Cregger's autobiography, the inversion acquires a further sense. The *Bacchae* is the Western tradition's founding drama of intoxication as possession. A film written by a recovering alcoholic about a substance that seizes a household ends with the substance torn apart by the very compulsion it produced. It is a recovering addict's fantasy rendered as myth: that the force of the craving could one day be turned against its source.

VII.2 The horde and the broken totem

In *Totem and Taboo* (1913) Freud proposed that the sons of a primal horde, excluded by a jealous father, banded together, killed him, and devoured him, and that their subsequent guilt instituted the totem prohibition and with it the moral law. *Weapons* inverts the scenario's gender, replacing the primal father with a devouring elder who resembles Creed's archaic mother, and it retains the essential structure: a band of siblings who could not prevail singly destroys the

tyrant collectively. The encyclopaedic summary of the plot happens to describe the twig Alex breaks as a totem (production record). The accident is apt. The broken totem is the inverted totem meal, a rite that ends a tyranny rather than commemorating one.

Freud's horde, however, carries guilt, and the children of Maybrook cannot. They did not choose; they were operated. The guilt of the founding murder must therefore go somewhere else, and the coda shows where it goes. Alex, the one child who knew and acted, leaves the town to live with another aunt, while his parents are institutionalized. The city keeps its seventeen children and loses the one who saved them. The pattern is Oedipal in the strict Sophoclean sense: the one who solves the riddle and lifts the plague departs the city whose order his knowledge restored. The structure of the scapegoat, expelled from the plot at the level of accusation, returns at the level of consequence.

VII.3 The problem of unanimity

For Girard the mark of the founding murder is unanimity: all against one. The climax of *Weapons* is the purest image of unanimity in recent popular cinema, seventeen bodies moving as one upon a single body, and it is staged for the audience's exhilaration. A Girardian critique would hold that the film, having exposed the scapegoat mechanism in its first half, satisfies the appetite for unanimous violence in its second, and that the guilt of Gladys merely licenses a pleasure the film had taught us to distrust.

The film's answer is not a denial but a structure. The counter-hex is homoeopathic in the original medical sense of Samuel Hahnemann's *Organon* (1810), whose principle that like cures like Frazer borrowed when he named imitative magic: the disease is turned upon itself. In Derrida's terms, the poison becomes the remedy by being redirected, without ceasing to be poison. The only means of undoing sympathetic violence is more sympathetic violence; the only way to free the weaponized children is to weaponize them again; the only person capable of performing the rite is a child who has learned the witch's craft by watching. This is the aporia of deliverance, and the film does not resolve it. It shows the cost. The children are freed into catatonia, and the boy who freed them is removed from the community he saved.

VII.4 Mythic and divine violence

Walter Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1921) distinguished mythic violence, which makes and preserves law, which is bloody, and which threatens, from divine violence, which destroys law, which expiates, and which is lethal without spilling blood. His example of mythic violence was the punishment of Niobe, whose children were killed by Apollo and Artemis for their mother's boast and

who was turned to weeping stone. Gladys's violence is Niobean: it takes children and petrifies their parents into something like Niobe's weeping rock. The children's counter-violence aspires to the divine. It destroys a law, the witch's sovereignty over a house and a town, and it is expiatory, ending the dominion of a guilty power. Yet it is spectacularly bloody, and it is entirely mediated by instruments. The film can imagine violence that wishes to be divine only in the form of the mythic. Deliverance borrows the grammar of possession because the film knows no other grammar of force.

Benjamin's essay also contains a remark that the film's ending appears to have understood. He argued that there exists a sphere of human agreement wholly inaccessible to violence, the sphere of understanding, which is language. The coda of *Weapons* does not end with the climax's force. It ends with children who, some time later, begin to speak again. The return of speech is the film's sole gesture toward a non-instrumental bond. The Conclusion takes up that gesture.

VII.5 Carnival and the baiting crowd

The pursuit of Gladys through the suburban streets is a carnival uncrowning in Bakhtin's sense: the tyrant, still in her clown's paint and wig, is chased, mocked by the absurdity of her own flight, and reduced to the body she had spent the film disguising. The tonal swerve into comedy is deliberate; Cregger has said that the comic in his films must arise from authentic reactions to bizarre situations rather than from jokes (Schiller 2025). Ray Bradbury's *Something Wicked This Way Comes* (1962) had already made laughter a weapon against witchcraft: the Dust Witch is destroyed by a bullet on which Charles Halloway has carved a smile. In *Weapons* the audience's laughter performs the same office, discharging the fear the witch induced.

But laughter is also collective, and here the analysis must not flinch. Elias Canetti's *Crowds and Power* (1960) described the baiting crowd, which forms around a quickly attainable goal, the killing of a single victim, and dissolves once the goal is reached. The children form a baiting crowd in the fiction; the audience, laughing and applauding as one, forms a second baiting crowd in the theatre. The film thereby implicates its spectators in the unanimity it stages. Whether this implication is critical or merely gratifying depends on whether the viewer notices it, and the narrated coda, with its mute children and its exiled boy, is the film's attempt to ensure that some do.

VII.6 The final child and the sorcerer's apprentice

Carol Clover's *Men, Women, and Chain Saws* (1992) identified the Final Girl of the slasher film: watchful, resourceful, androgynous, and victorious at the end, characteristically by seizing the killer's own weapon and turning it upon him.

Alex is a final child in exactly this sense. He survives by watching, he learns Gladys's procedure by observing it, and he defeats her by appropriating her instrument. Clover observed that the Final Girl's victory is purchased with a certain masculinization, a taking up of the phallic weapon. Alex's victory is purchased with a certain sorcerization: to unmake a witch, he must become, for the duration of one rite, a witch.

Goethe's ballad "Der Zauberlehrling" (1797) is the canonical image of the apprentice who uses his master's spell and cannot control its consequences. Alex's spell succeeds, but its excess, children bursting through walls and windows in the dark, exhibits a power far exceeding its purpose. The film leaves open whether the boy who learned this craft will carry it with him to his other aunt's house. That open question is the residue of the aporia of deliverance, and it is the most honest thing the ending contains.

VIII

Strings Equally Wound

Toward a General Theory of Sympathetic Violence

The magical, moral, and indexical sympathies traced in the preceding chapters are not three analogies but one operation, the transmission of motion along a bond already in place, running through three media: matter, passion, and image. *Weapons* is constructed so that in every medium harm travels by contact while the town searches by likeness and by pointing, and so that the last body the operation reaches is the spectator's.

VIII.1

One mechanism, three media

The identity is not imposed by this study; its theorists confess it themselves. Frazer did not regard the laws of magic as alien to ordinary thought. "If my analysis of the magician's logic is correct," he wrote, "its two great principles turn out to be merely two different misapplications of the association of ideas": homoeopathic magic misapplies association by similarity, while contagious magic "commits the mistake of assuming that things which have once been in contact with each other are always in contact" (*The Golden Bough*, 1922, ch. 3). The association of ideas is Hume's doctrine. The *Treatise* reduces the connections of thought to three relations, resemblance, contiguity in time or place, and cause and effect (1.1.4), and when it turns to the passions it explains sympathy by the same relations: the idea of another person's feeling is enlivened into a feeling of one's own in proportion as that person resembles us, stands near us, or is bound to us by blood or acquaintance (2.1.11). The relations that make Frazer's magician err are the relations that make Hume's moral community cohere. Hume even reaches for the word Frazer would later choose. "We suffer by contagion and sympathy," the second *Enquiry* observes, "nor can we remain indifferent spectators" (*An Enquiry Concerning the Principles of Morals*, 1751).

Peirce carried the same pair into the theory of signs, dividing the icon, which signifies by resemblance, from the index, which signifies by a real connection with its object; Jakobson, as Chapter IV showed, aligned both with Frazer's laws and with the metaphoric and metonymic poles of language. A single mechanism therefore runs through matter in Frazer, through passion in Hume, and through the sign in Peirce: association by likeness and by contact. It becomes *sympathy* wherever the association is efficacious, wherever an idea, a token, or an image does not merely recall its object but moves it.

The genealogy is older than its modern theorists. The Stoics held the cosmos to be a single living body whose parts suffer together, and they pointed to the tides that rise and fall with the moon. Cicero, mocking in *De Divinatione* (2.34) the inference of private fortunes from the fissures of a liver, nonetheless gave the doctrine its enduring Latin: a natural kinship of distant things, a *concentus atque consensus*, literally a singing-together and a feeling-together. Hume's strings equally wound up restore the musical figure Cicero chose. In the early modern literature of sympathy and antipathy, of which Girolamo Fracastoro's *De*

sympathia et antipathia rerum (1546) is a landmark, the resonance of tuned strings was a stock illustration, and the viola d'amore still carries "sympathetic strings" that sound without being touched. Gladys's bell belongs to this acoustics. It does not strike the bodies it stills; it sounds, and the bodies tuned to it stop.

Two historians mark the stakes. Michel Foucault, reconstructing the sixteenth-century episteme in *The Order of Things* (1966), counted sympathy among the four similitudes that bound the world together and warned of its peculiar power: unchecked by its twin, antipathy, sympathy would assimilate things until their individuality vanished and the world contracted into a homogeneous mass. Seventeen children running in a single posture at a single hour toward a single house are that contraction made visible. Seth Lobis's *The Virtue of Sympathy* (2015) follows the concept through seventeenth-century English magic, natural philosophy, and literature as it becomes a human virtue. *Weapons* runs the history backward: it takes the virtue of a neighbourly town and shows the magic still inside it.

Freud supplies the generic consequence. "The Uncanny" distinguishes a class of uncanny experience that arises not from the return of the repressed but from the apparent confirmation of beliefs a culture supposes it has surmounted: the omnipotence of thoughts, the efficacy of magic. Horror is the genre in which Frazer's "mistake" ceases to be one. In Maybrook, things once in contact remain in contact. The deepest horror of *Weapons* is therefore not the existence of a witch but the discovery that what Hume took to be the ordinary life of the passions, motion passing along strings, is literally true of limbs.

VIII.2 The weapon-salve: a prehistory of the title

The title has a forgotten referent in the history of sympathy. In the early seventeenth century Paracelsian physicians recommended the *unguentum armarium*, the weapon-salve: an ointment applied not to the wound but to the weapon that had made it, on the principle that the blood left on the blade remained in sympathy with the body it came from. The practice acquired a learned name, *hoplocrisma*, the anointing of a weapon, and a pan-European controversy. Rudolph Goclenius defended a magnetic cure of wounds; Jan Baptist van Helmont's treatise on the same subject (1621) drew him into ecclesiastical investigation; Francis Bacon recorded the cure, with characteristic reserve, in *Sylva Sylvarum* (1627). In England the clergyman William Foster attacked it in *Hoplocrisma-Spongus*, a sponge to wipe the salve away, arguing that the cure was magical and unlawful, and in 1631 Robert Fludd replied that it was natural and "no way Cacomagicall." The recipe, in the version Charles Mackay reproduced in *Extraordinary Popular Delusions and the Madness of Crowds* (1841),

compounded the dead into a medicine for the living: moss from the skull of a hanged thief, "real mummy," warm human blood.

The controversy culminated in Sir Kenelm Digby's *Late Discourse… Touching the Cure of Wounds by the Powder of Sympathy* (1658), whose central anecdote reads like a treatment for *Weapons*. James Howell, wounded in the hand while parting two duelling friends, gave Digby a garter stained with his blood. Digby dissolved his powder, which was vitriol, in a basin of water and laid the garter in it, and Howell, talking at the other side of the room, felt a sudden coolness. Later Digby dried the garter before the fire, and Howell's servant came running to report that his master's hand was burning; when the garter went back into the water, the pain ceased.

The correspondence with Gladys's rite is nearly element for element: a blooded token, an instrument, and a bowl of water in which the operation concludes. The relation is an inversion. The salve healed the wounded by treating the weapon. Gladys wounds the living by anointing a weapon of her own, a thorned twig wound with a token and coated in her blood, and she ends the spell, as Digby soothed Howell, in water. Digby's anecdote also demonstrates, more than two centuries before Frazer, the bilaterality of contagion that Chapter IV found in the hair inside the wig: the garter that cools can burn, depending on who holds it and where. And the controversy's question, whether such operations are natural or magical, is the question Maybrook cannot settle about its own catastrophe. Fludd insisted on nature; Foster saw sorcery. The film's answer is that grief and addiction, which are natural, and witchcraft, which is not, share a single grammar. Whether by design or by the mediumistic method its author professes, *Weapons* names the very object around which early modern Europe argued about sympathy: the weapon as the node of a bond that outlasts contact, the point at which *pharmakon* and *hoplon*, drug and weapon, meet. The pharmacology of mourning named in this study's subtitle has its historical emblem here.

VIII.3 Moral sympathy and its corruptions

Hume's founding image deserves to be read entire: "As in strings equally wound up, the motion of one communicates itself to the rest; so all the affections readily pass from one person to another, and beget correspondent movements in every human creature" (*Treatise* 3.3.1). Hume knew that the strings carry hatred as readily as love, and that they carry it to the innocent. A passion for or against a person, he observed, extends to everything contiguous with its object: "A quarrel with one person gives us a hatred for the whole family, tho' entirely innocent of that, which displeases us" (2.2.2). This is the scapegoat mechanism in the vocabulary of associationism, and it requires a refinement of Chapter IV's formula. Maybrook does not search by resemblance alone. Its hatred also travels from the event to whatever stands nearest it, and the nearest thing to an empty classroom

is the teacher whose classroom it was. Two contiguities must therefore be distinguished. Peirce separated the genuine index, bound to its object by an existential connection, from the degenerate index, whose relation to its object is a mere reference; a pointing finger directs attention without ever having been touched by what it indicates. The witch works by genuine indices, hair and name tags that touched the bodies they command. The town works by reference. It points, and the word painted in red on Justine's car is its characteristic sign: a finger made of letters.

Adam Smith completes the moral register by showing where sympathy becomes literal. "By the imagination," he wrote, "we place ourselves in his situation" (*The Theory of Moral Sentiments*, 1759, I.i.1.2), and the placing is bodily: the spectator who sees a blow aimed at another's leg draws back his own, and "the mob, when they are gazing at a dancer on the slack rope, naturally writhe and twist and balance their own bodies, as they see him do." Smith extended the operation to the dead. We pity them, he argued, by "lodging, if I may be allowed to say so, our own living souls in their inanimated bodies" (I.i.1.13), and from this illusion comes our dread of death. Gladys is Smith's illusion reversed and made true. Where the mourner lodges a living soul imaginatively in a dead body, the dying woman lodges her failing life materially in living ones. Archer, sleeping in Matthew's bed, performs the mourner's version; Gladys, drinking the vitality of seventeen children, performs the witch's.

Smith also derived punishment from sympathy. The spectator of a murder enters into the victim's situation and seems in imagination to "animate anew the deformed and mangled carcase of the slain," and the ghosts that superstition raises to demand vengeance, Smith concluded, take their origin from "this natural sympathy with the imaginary resentment of the slain" (II.i.2.5). Maybrook's witch-hunt is sympathetic resentment on behalf of children who are not even dead, whose resentment is wholly imagined, and who have no voice in the vengeance taken in their name. The climax then literalizes Smith's superstition: bodies animated anew rise and pursue the one who wronged them. What Smith diagnosed as an illusion of the imagination, the film stages as plot. Smith's corrective was the impartial spectator, the observer within the breast who tempers the partiality of our sympathies. Maybrook has none. Its spectators are either partial, at the town meeting, or impartial and blind, behind the doorbell lenses. The film supplies the missing figure formally, through a chaptered structure that grants each suspect a hearing.

Max Scheler's *The Nature of Sympathy* (1913; revised 1923) names the corruption precisely. Scheler distinguished four phenomena: community of feeling, whose paradigm in his account is two parents standing beside the body of their dead child and sharing one sorrow; fellow-feeling, in which one person responds to another's feeling as another's; emotional infection, the involuntary transmis-

sion of affect through a crowd, which he held to be no genuine sympathy at all; and emotional identification, infection's extreme, in which the boundary between selves dissolves, as in hypnosis or the mass. Maybrook begins with Scheler's paradigm multiplied by seventeen and degrades it, at the town meeting, into infection. Gladys completes the descent into identification, the hypnotic merger in which one will occupies many bodies. The film's moral argument can be stated in Scheler's terms: genuine sympathy depends on a distance between persons that infection and identification abolish, and the witch-hunt and the witchcraft are two ways of abolishing it.

VIII.4 Three grieving fathers

The theory predicts the fate of the bereaved from the way they search, and the comparative record bears the prediction out. In Nicolas Roeg's *Don't Look Now* (1973), from Daphne du Maurier's story of 1971, John Baxter is examining a slide of a church interior when water spills across it and the red of a small hooded figure bleeds over the image; at that moment, outside, his daughter drowns in her red coat. The image wounds at a distance, an index of an event it could not have recorded. In Venice, John follows a small figure in a red coat because it resembles his daughter. It turns, and it is a murderous dwarf with an aged face, who kills him. His visions, which are veridical, he misreads.

Denis Villeneuve's *Prisoners* (2013), which Cregger names as a pervasive model, is set, like *Weapons*, in a small Pennsylvania town. Two girls vanish, and one of their fathers, Keller Dover, abducts and tortures Alex Jones, a young man with the mind of a child who matches the father's idea of an abductor. The abductor is Holly Jones, the elderly woman known as Alex's aunt, who with her husband began taking children after their son died, as a war on God; she keeps her captives drugged and finally drops the father into a hidden pit in her yard. The kinship of the two films is structural: a bereaved elderly woman called aunt, a ward named Alex, captive children stupefied and hidden below ground. Cregger reverses the valences. Villeneuve's Alex is the aunt's damaged captive and the father's scapegoat; Cregger's Alex is the aunt's captive accomplice and the children's deliverer.

Archer Graff is the third father and the only one who ignores resemblance. He does not ask who looks guilty. He follows vectors, collating the trajectories of seventeen children until their convergence yields a house. He finds the crone, is weaponized by her, survives, and carries his son home. The triptych sorts its fathers exactly as the theory requires. Resemblance kills Baxter. Sympathetic resentment, discharged upon the resembling innocent, entombs Dover. Contiguity, followed with the patience of a hunter reading tracks, lets Archer bring his child home, though only after he has himself been made a weapon.

VIII.5

The indexical register: cinema as contagious magic

Peirce's own paradigm of the index is a weapon's trace: "a piece of mould with a bullet hole in it," which signifies a shot "for without the shot there would have been no hole" (*Collected Papers* 2.304). The hole remains a sign, Peirce added, whether or not anyone has the sense to attribute it to a shot. That is the condition of the doorbell archive before Archer reads it: a town full of genuine indices that no one has interpreted. The photographic image belongs to the same family, and its classical theorists described it in the language of contagious magic.

André Bazin's "Ontology of the Photographic Image" (1945) traced the plastic arts to the embalming impulse, a "mummy complex," the wish to preserve being against time, and argued that photography satisfies it because its image arises automatically, by a transfer of reality from the thing to its reproduction. Bazin proposed a psychology of relics and souvenirs, which enjoy the same transfer, and noted that the Shroud of Turin is relic and photograph at once; the cinema, which records duration, he called "change mummified." The relic is the hinge object of this entire study. Hume had explained the devotion of the superstitious to the relics of saints as an enlivening of belief by the relation that binds a relic to its saint (*Treatise* 1.3.8); Frazer's contagious magic is a science of relics; the weapon-salve was compounded of mummy. Gladys's tokens are relics inverted: not remains of the holy dead used to bless the living, but remains of the living used to sustain the dying. Her project is the mummy complex performed on other people's bodies, and the children she keeps upright in the basement, held in a preserved present, are change mummified in the flesh.

Roland Barthes's *Camera Lucida* (1980) radicalized Bazin. The essence of the photograph is its "that-has-been": the image is an emanation of its referent, joined to the viewer's gaze by light, which Barthes treated as a kind of shared skin, an umbilical tie between the photographed body and the eye. The detail that wounds the viewer he called the *punctum*, taking the word from the Latin for a prick, a puncture, the mark of a pointed instrument; it rises from the scene, he wrote, and pierces like an arrow. Barthes's theory of the photograph is thus a theory of being pricked at a distance through a trace, which is exactly Gladys's procedure. The film contains three such pricks: the thorn of the rite, the needle that sticks Paul during his search of James, and the image that pierces its viewer. In Barthes's own figure, the photograph is a weapon.

Susan Sontag made the figure explicit. In "In Plato's Cave," the essay that opens *On Photography* (1977), she called the camera a sublimation of the gun and the act of photographing a "soft murder," and observed that cameras, like guns and cars, are fantasy-machines whose use is addictive. Weapon, image, and drug, the three terms of this study, meet in a single sentence of photographic theory. The same essay discusses Nick Ut's photograph of 1972, the naked child running down the road toward the camera with her arms spread, as an image

that did more to turn public feeling against the war than any quantity of televised atrocity. Chapter II showed that Cregger modelled the running children on that photograph and reversed their vector. Sontag allows the reversal to be stated completely. In Ut's frame the child runs from the weapon toward the camera. In *Weapons* the children run from the cameras mounted at their thresholds toward the weapon. Camera and weapon have exchanged places, and Sontag's equation of the two is performed as choreography.

The film's diegetic images can now be classified by regime. The doorbell recordings are genuine indices awaiting an interpreter. The camera in Paul's cruiser records his assault on James, an index he cannot unmake, and turns the officer into a suspect in his own archive. The dreams in which Gladys visits Justine, Archer, and James are emanations in Barthes's sense, images sent by their referent; they are veridical, and no one consults them. The one sign the town produces itself is a word that points. Over all of them presides the gesture of the running child, which Aby Warburg would have called a *Pathosformel*, a formula of pathos. Warburg introduced the term in a 1905 lecture on Dürer and Italian antiquity, discussing Dürer's drawing of the death of Orpheus, the poet torn apart by maenads, and he understood such gestures as charges of affect that survive across centuries and discharge in new settings. The posture of the children of Maybrook descends from the maenad of Chapter VII, passes through Ut's photograph, and arrives on a suburban lawn still carrying its charge. Warburg's theory of tradition is itself a theory of sympathy: images as strings that go on sounding long after the hand that plucked them is gone.

VIII.6

The spectator as instrument

The last body the operation reaches is the viewer's. Linda Williams's "Film Bodies: Gender, Genre, and Excess" (1991) grouped horror with melodrama and pornography as body genres, marked by the spectacle of a body seized by sensation and by the spectator's "almost involuntary mimicry" of it, an apparent want of aesthetic distance. Smith's mob writhing beneath the rope-dancer anticipated the argument by more than two centuries. Williams also assigned each genre a temporality: horror's fantasy arrives "too early," before the victim is ready, melodrama's "too late," after the loss. *Weapons* fuses the two. Its catastrophe falls at 2:17 a.m., before anyone is awake to prevent it; its consolations arrive slowly and afterward, in a coda where speech returns gradually and not to every child, and where Archer carries home a son who cannot yet answer him. Williams's own instance of the genre's habit of measuring success in its audience's bodies was William Castle, whose *The Tingler* (1959) wired cinema seats to deliver vibrations and imagined a creature fed by fear that only a scream could subdue: a homoeopathic cure in which fear is discharged through

fear's own expression, as Chapter VII found the audience's laughter discharging the fear of the witch.

Jean-Louis Baudry's apparatus theory (1970; 1975) read Plato's cave as the prototype of cinema: spectators immobilized in darkness, facing images they take for reality, regressing toward the condition of the dreamer. Sontag's essay begins in the same cave. *Weapons* builds one. Seventeen children stand upright and silent in the dark of a basement, unable to move, sustained on what is carried down to them, while what is drawn out of them nourishes a figure upstairs. The image is the film's most implicating, because it describes the condition of its own audience: bodies held still in the dark whose attention and affect are a resource to be drawn on, by a film and by an industry that has already scheduled the witch's return. Gladys is, among her other identities, a portrait of the horror filmmaker, one who moves bodies at a distance by manipulating traces, stages the children's run, and paints her own face into a mask. The film makes the reflexivity operative through Alex. In his chapter the audience watches the ritual in procedural detail, and by the climax it knows the spell as well as he does and wants it used. The spectator is the sorcerer's other apprentice, the one who learned by watching, and the exhilaration that greets the counter-hex is the audience willing the children's second weaponization. Hume's sentence describes the result: we suffer by contagion and sympathy, and we cannot remain indifferent spectators.

The category is portable. Wherever horror locates its threat in a bond rather than an impact, the theory applies, and the genre's characteristic cures prove homoeopathic. In Suzuki Kōji's novel *Ring* (1991) and Nakata Hideo's film *Ringu* (1998), a curse travels by the viewing of a videotape and can be survived only by copying the tape and showing it to someone else: the cure is the manufacture of another spectator. In David Robert Mitchell's *It Follows* (2014), a curse passes by sexual contact, and the follower that walks toward its victim is pure vector, the index of a past touch advancing at walking pace; it too can only be passed on. In Bernard Rose's *Candyman* (1992), from Clive Barker's story "The Forbidden" (1985), a name repeated before a mirror summons a figure who exists because he is told. In Ari Aster's *Hereditary* (2018), kinship itself is the conduit through which a cult operates a family. Each is a case of sympathetic violence, and each places a viewer, a lover, a speaker, or a child at the end of a string.

VIII.7 Propositions on sympathetic violence

The argument of this dissertation can now be stated as a theory. The table summarizes its three registers; the propositions that follow state the laws common to all three.

Register	Originators	What travels	Channel in *Weapons*	Characteristic error	Counter-practice
Magical	The Stoics; Frazer; Mauss and Hubert; the weapon-salve physicians	Will, motion, vitality	Hair, name tags, blood on a thorn, the bell	The sorcerer neglects her own residue	The counter-hex: the spell turned on its author
Moral	Hume; Smith; Scheler	Passion, grief, resentment	Kinship, neighbourhood, the town meeting, the word on the car	Fellow-feeling degraded into infection; proximity and likeness taken for cause	The chaptered form: a hearing for every suspect
Indexical	Peirce; Bazin; Barthes; Sontag; Williams; Warburg	Light, sensation, gesture	Doorbell footage, the cruiser camera, dreams, the spectator's body	An archive without a reader; an audience converted into a crowd	Evidential reading; narration that restores distance

Proposition I

Every bond is a channel. A tie that can carry care can carry command; the capacity to be affected by another is the capacity to be moved by another. Gladys enters by kinship, and the strings that make a town a community are the strings by which it is operated.

Proposition II

Every residue is a handle. Persons shed traces, hair, names, images, reputations, data, and whoever holds a trace holds a handle on the person. The name tag, the doorbell recording, and the reputation written on a car are objects of one kind.

Proposition III

Harm touches; accusation points. Sympathetic harm travels by genuine indices, things that were in contact. Communities search for it by icons and by reference, by likeness and by pointing. Hence the persecution of the resembling innocent and the invisibility of the contiguous guilty.

Proposition IV

Kinetic violence strikes instruments. A bullet stops a body; only a trace reaches a will. Justine's shots kill two men who were only instruments and leave the agent untouched.

Proposition V

Every channel runs both ways. Whoever binds is bound by the same bond, and the sorcerer's residues are as available as her victims'. Digby's garter cools and burns; the hair inside the wig unmakes the witch.

Proposition VI

The cure is a dose of the disease. Sympathetic violence can be undone only sympathetically, and every deliverance borrows the grammar of possession. This is the aporia of Chapter VII, and it is also the law of the cursed tape and of the Tingler's scream.

Proposition VII

To watch is to be wound. Spectatorship is a bond, and the spectator of sympathetic violence is its last instrument, moved at a distance, through an index, by a

will not its own.

Proposition VIII

Only distance disarms. The one circulation of sympathy that does not become command preserves the interval between selves: Scheler's fellow-feeling as against infection, Smith's impartial spectator as against the mob, Warburg's *Denkraum* as against the instant.

The last proposition requires a gloss. On 21 April 1923, at Ludwig Binswanger's clinic in Kreuzlingen, Warburg lectured on the serpent ritual of the Pueblo peoples, with images from the journey he had made among them in 1895–96. Magical and symbolic thought, he argued, for all their terror, create a space between humanity and the world, a space for devotion or for thought, *Andachtsraum* or *Denkraum*, and the electric instant destroys it: telegraph and telephone, he said, are destroying the cosmos. Sympathetic violence is the abolition of that space, will passing into limb without interval, action at a distance without distance. The doorbell network, the overnight spread of an accusation, and the spell share the temporality of the instant. Against them *Weapons* sets only slow forms: Archer's map, assembled from the footage of seventeen doorsteps; Alex's watching; and, long after the night of the spell, a child's narration. The Conclusion argues that this last slow form is the film's answer to everything that precedes it.

Conclusion

After the Spell

Weapons ends not in deliverance but in convalescence. The spell breaks in a single night, speech returns over months, and the film's last proposal, made quietly through its narrator, is that the one sympathy which does not become command is the slow one, narration, because it preserves the distance that sympathetic violence abolishes.

Speech recovered

The seventeen children come home mute, and some, in time, begin to speak again. The asymmetry of tempos is the film's final argument: possession was instantaneous, recovery is gradual. Chapter VII took from Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" the claim that there is a sphere of human agreement inaccessible to violence, the sphere of understanding, which is language. The return of speech is the sign that each body again contains a self distinct from the will that moved it, since no one can narrate a possession while possessed. To speak is to stand at a distance from what happened to one's limbs. In Scheler's terms, speech restores the interval without which there is infection or identification but no fellow-feeling; in Warburg's, it reopens the *Denkraum*. In Freud's, it completes the game with which this study began. The child of *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* mastered his mother's absence not by the string alone but by the syllables he attached to the reel's departure and return. The children of Maybrook were gone and are there, and what binds the two states at the end is not a tether of hair but words.

The legend as *pharmakon*

The words are not the children's own. They belong to an unseen girl who tells the story as something that really happened in her town, and the form she chooses is legend. Walter Benjamin's "The Storyteller" (1936) argued that the storyteller borrows authority from death, and that half the art of storytelling lies in keeping a story free of explanation, so that the listener is left to interpret. The coda obeys both rules. Its authority is the near-death of a classroom, and it declines to explain, above all, what will become of Alex. At the head of the chapter on action in *The Human Condition* (1958), Hannah Arendt placed Isak Dinesen's remark that "all sorrows can be borne" once they are put into a story. That is the legend's remedial face. It converts an unbearable event into a bearable tale, and it does what no spell in the film can do: it moves its listeners without moving their limbs. The difference between being moved and being operated is the difference the whole film has laboured to establish.

But a *pharmakon* is never only a remedy. In the *Phaedrus* the god Theuth offers writing to King Thamus as a drug for memory, and Thamus replies that it is a drug for reminding rather than remembering, one that will plant forgetful-

ness in the souls of those who use it. Derrida's reading of that exchange, from which this study took its pharmacology, applies to the coda exactly. The legend remembers by forgetting. As Chapter II showed, it says nothing of James, shot dead in the Lilly house, of Terry Miller, killed by his bewitched husband, or of Marcus, killed in traffic while under the spell. It keeps the seventeen and spends the rest. The coda is also, as Chapter I argued, a secondary revision, added after test audiences rejected an ending on a silent image of Matthew. Barthes declined to reproduce the photograph of his mother as a child that wounded him, because for anyone else it would be merely an image. The film's makers withdrew a silent image of a returned child, which might have wounded, and supplied a story in its place. The substitution trades the *punctum* for a legend so that the wound can be borne, and the trade is the film's last *pharmakon*.

The poison carries a further dose. Narration does not only console; it summons. In *Candyman* a monster exists because his legend is repeated, and the repetition is his sustenance. The announced prequel, *Gladys*, will tell the chapter the original withheld, and Chapter III predicted on Girardian grounds that it will rehabilitate the figure the original destroyed. Whatever its content, it confirms that the channel runs both ways at the level of the franchise as well as the fiction. The story that allowed Maybrook to bury its witch is the string by which she will be drawn back up.

The apprentice

The question the legend leaves open is the residue that Chapter VII identified in the aporia of deliverance. Alex learned the spell by watching, used it once, and leaves Maybrook to live with another aunt. Neither the narrator nor the film says what he carries with him. The silence is the coda's most honest gesture, because it refuses both answers that would close the aporia: that the craft died with the witch, and that the boy has become a witch himself. Where a verdict would stand, it leaves a space for thought. If narration is the remedy the film proposes, this unexplained boy measures how little the remedy can promise.

Contribution

This dissertation has argued that *Weapons* is an inquiry into how persons become instruments, and that its answer is sympathy in three registers that prove to be one: the magical sympathy of Frazer's contagion, the moral sympathy of Hume, Smith, and Scheler, and the indexical sympathy of the photographic image from Peirce through Bazin and Barthes to Sontag, each a form of association made efficacious. From that identity it derived the category of sympathetic violence, violence that rides existing bonds instead of crossing gaps by impact, and stated its laws: bonds are channels and residues are handles; harm touches

while accusation points; kinetic force strikes only instruments; every channel runs both ways; the cure is a dose of the disease; spectatorship is a bond; only distance disarms. Along the way it offered a reconstruction of the film's fabula and polyphonic syuzhet, a comparative mythography of the child-taking crone, a triptych of grieving fathers that tests the theory against *Don't Look Now* and *Prisoners*, and a prehistory of the film's title in the seventeenth-century controversy over the weapon-salve.

Limits and further research

Four limits should be stated. First, the study leans on authorial testimony given during a single promotional season, and Cregger's own poetics, which distrusts intellectualization, counsels against treating that testimony as a key. Second, the film's textual field is unfinished: the prequel will alter it, and a reading of Gladys as the figure denied a chapter may have to become a reading of a figure granted one. Third, the claims made about spectatorship, the baiting crowd, the body genre, the audience as apprentice, are theoretical and invite empirical study of reception, including how differently audiences received the climax's comedy. Fourth, the comparative corpus is weighted toward European and North American sources. Two directions would correct the imbalance. Japanese folk tradition explains vanished children as *kamikakushi*, concealment by the gods, and Yanagita Kunio's *Tōno monogatari* (1910) records a girl who vanished and returned decades later as an old woman: the crone as the missing child come home. The Mexican and Mexican-American legend of La Llorona, the weeping mother who drowned her children and wanders the water's edge in search of them, is a typological cousin of Lamia and a further figure of mourning turned predatory. Beyond mythography, the pharmacological thread could be extended through Avital Ronell's *Crack Wars* (1992) and Derrida's interview "The Rhetoric of Drugs" (1989), and the theory of sympathetic violence could be tested on networked media, where images, reputations, and affects travel by contagion at the speed Warburg feared, and where the doorbell cameras of Maybrook already look like antiques.

The strings remain wound. The film does not propose that they be cut, which would end sympathy and with it community. It proposes, tentatively and in a child's voice, that they be played slowly enough for each string to remain itself.

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Zach Cregger, Weapons *(2025), horror studies, film philosophy, comparative mythology, sympathetic violence, sympathetic magic, law of contagion, association of ideas, moral sentiments, emotional infection, indexicality, photographic ontology, punctum, body genres, apparatus theory, Pathosformel, Denkraum, weapon-salve, powder of sympathy, pharmakon, pharmacology of mourning, scapegoat mechanism, witch-hunt, spectral evidence, standing-reserve, poem of force, zombi, monstrous-feminine, female grotesque, hostipitality, crypt and phantom, parasitic senescence, sparagmos, Bacchae, mythic and divine violence, baiting crowd, Final Girl, aporia of deliverance, the eerie, the uncanny, grievability, mourning and melancholia, addiction, polyphonic monody, focalization, child narrator, legend, secondary revision, suburban gothic, child-taking crone, Pied Piper of Hamelin, Hansel and Gretel, Baba Yaga, Lamia, Lilith*



Set in TeX Gyre Schola, a revival of Century Schoolbook, the face Morris Fuller Benton drew for American school texts.